Bound reference

Notes on every topic in the 2023–2027 study design (the rules, formulas, methods, worked examples with every step, the traps examiners keep reporting, and a summary), with the hardest real VCAA questions on each topic after its notes: 31 questions from the 2023–2025 exams, chosen by how Victorian students actually scored.

How to use it

- Tab each topic. The topic name is in every footer, and the contents has the page numbers.
- The wide outer margin is for your own notes: CAS syntax for your calculator, your mistakes, extra examples.
- After each topic, try its hardest questions before reading the answer. The percentage is the share of students who got it right (multiple choice) or the average share of marks (written). ★ marks a topic with nothing in the hardest third of 2023–2025, so its hardest question there is.

VCAA rules for a bound reference (check the current year's list)

- Book format, A4 or smaller when closed.
- No pages, or parts of pages, that can come out during the exam: loose pages are removed and reported as a possible breach.
- Anything you add must be firmly attached, e.g. with glue, tape or staples.
- Get it properly bound, and ask your school whether they accept spiral or ring binding before relying on it.

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Methods exam technique

Command words in Methods

Phrase	What it means
Find / determine	Get the answer; show enough working for method marks if it's worth more than 1 mark.
Show that	The answer is given. Every step from the starting point to that answer must be written, with no jumps. A CAS "it's true" is worth 0.
Hence	You *must* use the previous part. Another method gets no marks.
Hence, or otherwise	The previous part is the quickest route, but any valid method is fine.
Exact value	No decimals: surds, π, e, logs and fractions stay as they are.
Correct to n decimal places	Round only the final answer, and use exactly n places (including trailing zeros: 0.50, not 0.5).
Sketch	Correct shape plus labelled key features (intercepts, turning points, asymptotes, endpoints with open/closed circles).
State / write down	No working needed.

Setting out for method marks

- **Write the setup before the answer.** For example: "Solve $f'(x) = 0$ for x" or "$P(X > 180)$ where $X \sim \mathrm{N}(170, 8^2)$". In Exam 2, a correct setup often earns the first mark even if the final answer is wrong.
- **Use correct notation.** $f'(x)$, not f' or $\frac{d}{dx}$ floating without an expression. Write $\int_0^2 (x^2 + 1)\,dx$ with brackets and dx. Use $=$ only between things that really are equal.
- **Define your variables** in modelling and probability questions: "Let X be the number of faulty items, $X \sim \mathrm{Bi}(20, 0.1)$."
- **Don't round intermediate values.** Carry full precision; round the final answer only.
- **State domains** for inverses, composites and derivatives, and for optimisation variables.

Exam 1 (tech-free) habits

- **Know your exact values** ($\sin\frac{\pi}{3}$ and so on), log and index laws, and the derivative and antiderivative table without thinking.
- **Factorise derivatives** before solving $= 0$.
- **Check solutions against domains**, especially for log equations and trig equations over restricted intervals.
- **Simplify at the end** ($\log_e 9 - \log_e 3 = \log_e 3$), but don't waste time making it "prettier" than needed.

Exam 2 (CAS) habits

- **Define functions on CAS** (e.g. `define f(x) = …`) so you can reuse them for derivatives, integrals and solve commands.
- **Check the mode**: radians, and approximate vs exact as needed.
- **Restrict solves to the domain** (e.g. `solve(f(x)=0, x) | 0≤x≤2π`) to avoid extra solutions.
- **Sketch what CAS gives you** and sanity-check it (range of a probability, sign of an area, sensible units).
- **Watch cube roots of negatives and $x^{2/3}$**: some CAS settings return complex values or only the $x \geq 0$ branch.

Multiple choice strategy

- Eliminate options by testing numbers (for functional equations, transformations, domains).
- For “which is true” questions, check *every* option: two can look right until you simplify.
- Never leave one blank: there's no penalty for wrong answers.
- Watch strict vs non-strict inequalities and open vs closed endpoints. These are the most common MCQ traps.

Your bound reference

- Organise it by topic with tabs. Include worked examples of the question types you find hard, not a copy of the textbook.
- A head start: the printable bound reference has the hardest real 2023–2025 questions by topic, with answers and marking points.
- Include the CAS syntax you use for: inverse normal, binomial cdf, solving with a domain, defining piecewise functions, and Newton's method.
- Add a page of your personal mistakes. Reading it during reading time is worth more than any formula.

Errors examiners' reports mention every year

Don't lose these marks

- Giving a decimal when an exact answer was asked for (or vice versa).
- “Show that” answers that skip steps or work backwards from the answer.
- Confusing “dilation from the x-axis” with “from the y-axis”.
- Missing open/closed circles, asymptote labels or endpoint coordinates on sketches.
- Not rejecting invalid solutions (negative lengths, logs of negatives, values outside the domain).
- Using $\mathrm{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$ with the variance as the standard deviation.
- Off-by-one errors in binomial inequalities ($P(X > 3)$ vs $P(X \geq 3)$).
- Calculating signed area when “area” was asked for.
- Writing the answer to a different question: x instead of the maximum value, or the probability instead of the expected number.

Reading time plan (15 minutes)

1. Skim the whole paper. Mark each question as easy, medium or hard.
2. For Exam 2 Section B, read the stem of each question and note which topic(s) it tests.
3. Plan your order: bank the easy marks first, but don't skip the start of a long question, since part (a) is usually quick.
4. Mentally set up the first few MCQs, so you start writing fast.

START HERE

Methods formula sheet & must-knows

VCAA provides a Methods formula sheet in both exams (mensuration, the derivative and antiderivative rules, and the probability and statistics formulas). Many things you use constantly aren't on it: exact values, log laws, transformations and the discriminant. Treat this page as a revision summary. Always check the current official sheet from the VCAA website before your exam.

Algebra and functions

Quadratics

$$x = \frac{-b \pm \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}}{2a} \qquad \Delta = b^2 - 4ac$$

$\Delta > 0$: two roots; $= 0$: one; < 0: none. Turning point at $x = -\frac{b}{2a}$. Systems

Polynomials

$$P(a) = 0 \iff (x - a) \text{ is a factor}$$

$$a^3 \pm b^3 = (a \pm b)(a^2 \mp ab + b^2)$$

Polynomials

Index and log laws

$$a^m a^n = a^{m+n} \quad (a^m)^n = a^{mn}$$

$$\log(xy) = \log x + \log y \quad \log x^n = n \log x \quad \log_a x =$$

Exponentials & logs

Transformations

$$y = af(n(x - h)) + k$$

$$(x, y) \to \left(\tfrac{x}{n} + h,\ ay + k\right)$$

Dilation from the x-axis = vertical. Transformations

Circular functions

$$y = a\sin(n(x - h)) + k: \text{ period } \tfrac{2\pi}{n},\ \text{amplitude } |a|$$

$$\tan: \text{ period } \tfrac{\pi}{n} \qquad \sin^2 x + \cos^2 x = 1$$

Circular functions

Composite and inverse

$$f \circ g \text{ exists} \iff \operatorname{ran} g \subseteq \operatorname{dom} f$$

$$\operatorname{dom} f^{-1} = \operatorname{ran} f$$

Composite & inverse

Calculus

Derivatives

$$\frac{d}{dx}x^n = nx^{n-1} \quad \frac{d}{dx}e^{kx} = ke^{kx} \quad \frac{d}{dx}\log_e(kx) = \frac{1}{x}$$

$$\frac{d}{dx}\sin(kx) = k\cos(kx) \quad \frac{d}{dx}\cos(kx) = -k\sin(kx) \quad \frac{d}{d}$$

Differentiation rules

Chain, product, quotient

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = \frac{dy}{du}\frac{du}{dx} \quad (uv)' = u'v + uv' \quad \left(\frac{u}{v}\right)' = \frac{u'v - uv'}{v^2}$$

Antiderivatives

$$\int x^n dx = \frac{x^{n+1}}{n+1} + c \quad \int \frac{1}{x}dx = \log_e|x| + c \quad \int e^{kx}d$$

$$\int \sin(kx)dx = -\frac{1}{k}\cos(kx) + c \quad \int \cos(kx)dx = \frac{1}{k}\sin$$

Antidifferentiation

Tangents and approximation

$$y - f(a) = f'(a)(x - a) \qquad m_{\text{normal}} = -\frac{1}{f'(a)}$$

$$f(x + h) \approx f(x) + hf'(x)$$

Applications

Integrals

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,dx = F(b) - F(a) \qquad f_{\text{avg}} = \frac{1}{b-a}\int_a^b f(x)\,d$$

Area between curves: $\int(\text{upper} - \text{lower})$. Integration

First principles

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(x + h) - f(x)}{h}$$

Limits

Trapezium rule

$$\int_a^b f \approx \tfrac{h}{2}\left[f(x_0) + 2f(x_1) + \cdots + 2f(x_{n-1}) + f(x_n)\right]$$

Numerical integration

Newton's method

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$$

Newton's method

Probability and statistics

Probability rules

$P(A \cup B) = P(A) + P(B) - P(A \cap B)$

$P(A \mid B) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(B)}$ independent: $P(A \cap B) = P$

Probability

Discrete random variables

$E(X) = \sum xp(x)$ $\mathrm{Var}(X) = E(X^2) - \mu^2$

$E(aX + b) = aE(X) + b$ $\mathrm{Var}(aX + b) = a^2\,\mathrm{Var}$

DRVs

Binomial

$P(X = x) = \binom{n}{x} p^x (1-p)^{n-x}$ $E = np$ Var =

Binomial

Continuous random variables

$\int f = 1$ $E(X) = \int x f(x)\,dx$ $\mathrm{Var}(X) = \int x^2 f($

Median: area to the left $= \frac{1}{2}$. CRVs

Normal

$Z = \dfrac{X - \mu}{\sigma}$ $68\%/95\%/99.7\%$ within $1/2/3\sigma$

Normal

Sample proportions and CIs

$E(\hat{P}) = p$ $\mathrm{sd}(\hat{P}) = \sqrt{\frac{p(1-p)}{n}}$

$\hat{p} \pm z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}$, $z_{95\%} \approx 1.96$

Confidence intervals

Exact values (not on the sheet)

θ	0	$\frac{\pi}{6}$	$\frac{\pi}{4}$	$\frac{\pi}{3}$	$\frac{\pi}{2}$
sin	0	$\frac{1}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$	1
cos	1	$\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$	$\frac{1}{2}$	0
tan	0	$\frac{\sqrt{3}}{3}$	1	$\sqrt{3}$	–

Functions: domain, range, hybrids & modulus

Relations and functions

A **relation** is any set of ordered pairs (x, y). A **function** is a relation where every x-value has *exactly one* y-value.

- **Vertical line test:** a graph is a function if no vertical line cuts it more than once.
- **One-to-one:** every y-value comes from exactly one x-value (passes the horizontal line test too). Examples: $y = x^3$, $y = e^x$, $y = \log_e x$.
- **Many-to-one:** some y-values come from more than one x-value. Examples: $y = x^2$, $y = \cos x$, $y = |x|$.

Function notation

$$f : D \to \mathbb{R}, \quad f(x) = \ldots$$

D is the **domain** (allowed inputs). The **range** is the set of outputs actually produced. $\mathbb{R}$ here is the codomain, not the range.

Interval notation: $[a, b]$ includes both ends, (a, b) excludes both, $[a, b)$ includes a only. $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{2\}$ means "all reals except 2"; $\mathbb{R}^+ = (0, \infty)$.

Maximal (implied) domain

If no domain is given, use the largest set of real numbers for which the rule makes sense:

Rule contains	Condition
$\sqrt{g(x)}$	$g(x) \geq 0$
$\dfrac{1}{g(x)}$	$g(x) \neq 0$
$\log_e(g(x))$	$g(x) > 0$ (strictly)
$\tan(x)$	$x \neq \frac{\pi}{2} + k\pi,\ k \in \mathbb{Z}$

When a rule is a sum or product of pieces, the maximal domain is the **intersection** of the pieces' domains.

Worked example 1 **Maximal domain of a combination** 2 marks

Find the maximal domain of $f(x) = \sqrt{4 - x} + \dfrac{1}{x + 1}$.

Theory

The maximal domain is every x for which the rule makes sense. Square roots need a non-negative argument and fractions need a non-zero denominator. For a sum, both parts must be defined, so intersect the conditions.

1 **Square root:** $4 - x \geq 0 \Rightarrow x \leq 4$.

Using $\sqrt{u}$ needs $u \geq 0$

2 **Fraction:** $x + 1 \neq 0 \Rightarrow x \neq -1$.

Using $\dfrac{1}{u}$ needs $u \neq 0$

✓ $(-\infty, -1) \cup (-1, 4]$, which can also be written $(-\infty, 4] \setminus \{-1\}$.

Using $\mathrm{dom}(f + g) = \mathrm{dom} f \cap \mathrm{dom} g$

Finding the range on a restricted domain

Sketch the graph over the domain only, then read off the lowest and highest y-values. Check three things: **turning points** inside the domain, the values at the **endpoints**, and whether each endpoint is included.

Worked example 2 **Range with an open endpoint (trick)** 3 marks

Find the range of $f : [-1, 3) \to \mathbb{R},\ f(x) = x^2 - 2x$.

Theory

For a restricted quadratic, the range is set by the turning point (if it's in the domain) and the endpoint values. An excluded endpoint only matters if its y-value isn't produced anywhere else.

1 **Turning point:** $f(x) = (x-1)^2 - 1$, so the minimum is -1 at $x = 1$, which is in the domain.

Using $ax^2 + bx + c = a(x-h)^2 + k$

2 **Endpoints:** $f(-1) = 1 + 2 = 3$ (included, since -1 is in the domain); $f(3) = 9 - 6 = 3$ ($x = 3$ is excluded).

Using evaluate the endpoints

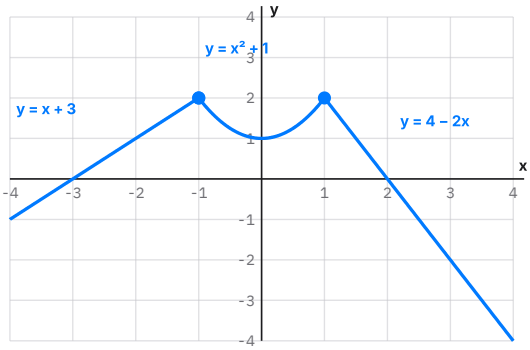
3 **Is 3 in the range?** Yes: even though $x = 3$ is excluded, the value 3 is still produced at $x = -1$.

Using check whether the value occurs elsewhere

Range $= [-1, 3]$. Many students write $[-1, 3)$ because of the open endpoint. Always check whether the "missing" value is produced somewhere else.

Hybrid (piecewise) functions

A hybrid function uses different rules on different parts of the domain. Sketch each piece only over its own interval, with a closed dot where an endpoint is included and an open dot where it isn't.



$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x + 3, & x < -1 \\ x^2 + 1, & -1 \le x \le 1 \\ 4 - 2x, & x > 1 \end{cases}$$: there's a jump at $x = -1$ (so it is not continuous there) but the pieces meet at $x = 1$.

Key idea

A hybrid function is **continuous** at a join if the pieces give the same value there. Continuity problems usually become "set the two rules equal at the join and solve for the unknown constant". Differentiability (a smooth join) is on the Limits, continuity & differentiability page.

Worked example 3 **Making a hybrid continuous** 2 marks

Find a so that $g(x) = \begin{cases} x^2 + a, & x \leq 2 \\ 3x - 1, & x > 2 \end{cases}$ is continuous at $x = 2$.

Theory

A hybrid function is continuous at a join when both pieces give the same value there, so the graph has no jump.

1 Both rules must give the same value at $x = 2$: $2^2 + a = 3(2) - 1$.

Using

$\lim_{x \to a^-} f(x) = \lim_{x \to a^+} f(x) = f(a)$

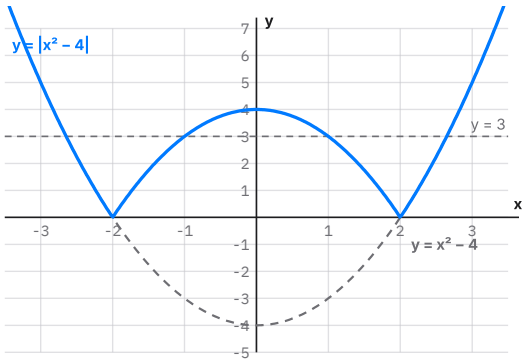
$4 + a = 5 \Rightarrow a = 1$.

The modulus function

Modulus (absolute value)

$$|x| = \begin{cases} x, & x \geq 0 \\ -x, & x < 0 \end{cases}$$

$|x|$ is the distance from 0. The graph of $y = |f(x)|$ is the graph of $y = f(x)$ with every part below the x-axis reflected up.



$y = x^2 - 4$ (dashed) and $y = |x^2 - 4|$ (solid). The part between $x = -2$ and $x = 2$ is flipped up, creating sharp corners at $x = \pm 2$.

Worked example 4 **Solving a modulus equation** 2 marks

Solve $|x^2 - 4| = 3$.

Theory

$|u| = k$ (with $k > 0$) means u is k units from zero, so $u = k$ or $u = -k$. Solve both equations.

1 Split into two equations: $x^2 - 4 = 3$ or $x^2 - 4 = -3$.

Using

$|u| = k \iff u = \pm k$

2 $x^2 = 7 \Rightarrow x = \pm\sqrt{7}$; $x^2 = 1 \Rightarrow x = \pm 1$.

Using

$x^2 = c \Rightarrow x = \pm\sqrt{c}$

$x = \pm 1, \pm\sqrt{7}$ (four solutions: check on the graph, where the line $y = 3$ cuts the W shape four times).

Trick alert: domain and range traps

- **Logs need strictly positive arguments.** $\log_e(x^2)$ has domain $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$, but $2\log_e x$ has domain $(0, \infty)$. They are only equal for $x > 0$.
- **Open endpoints aren't automatically open in the range** (see the worked example above).
- **Asymptotes are never reached.** The range of $y = 3 - \frac{2}{(x-1)^2}$ is $(-\infty, 3)$, not $(-\infty, 3]$.

Summary

- Function: one output per input. One-to-one: one input per output.
- Maximal domain: roots ≥ 0, denominators $\neq 0$, log arguments > 0; intersect the conditions.
- Range on a restricted domain: check turning points, endpoints and whether excluded values are produced elsewhere.
- Hybrid functions: sketch each piece on its own interval; continuity means the pieces agree at the join.
- $|f(x)|$: reflect the negative parts up; corners appear at the x-intercepts.

Hardest real questions on this topic

Nothing on this topic made the hardest third of 2023–2025, so this is the hardest one there is.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 3 ★ 47% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 3) ↗

Domain of the sum of two functions with domains [−2, 3) and (−1, 5]

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 3) ↗

Answer: E · A 22% · B 12% · C 11% · D 7% · E 47%

The sum's domain is the intersection: $(-1, 3)$.

Polynomials: factor theorem, cubics & quartics

Division, remainders and factors

Dividing a polynomial $P(x)$ by $(x-a)$ gives a quotient $Q(x)$ and a remainder R (a number):

Division statement

$$P(x) = (x-a)\,Q(x) + R$$

Substituting $x = a$ kills the first term, which gives the two theorems you use every week.

Remainder theorem

$$\text{The remainder when } P(x) \text{ is divided by } (x-a) \text{ is } P(a).$$

For a divisor $(bx-a)$ the remainder is $P\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)$.

Factor theorem

$$(x-a) \text{ is a factor of } P(x) \iff P(a) = 0.$$

Key idea

To factorise a cubic by hand: try the factors of the constant term ($\pm 1, \pm 2, \pm 3, \ldots$) until $P(a) = 0$, then divide by $(x-a)$ and factorise the quadratic that is left. With a non-monic leading coefficient, also try fractions $\pm \frac{\text{factor of constant}}{\text{factor of leading coeff}}$.

Worked example 1 **Factorising a cubic (tech-free)** 3 marks

Factorise $P(x) = 2x^3 - 3x^2 - 11x + 6$ and solve $P(x) = 0$.

Theory

The factor theorem: if $P(a) = 0$ then $(x-a)$ is a factor. Test small integer factors of the constant term (divided by factors of the leading coefficient), then divide to reduce the cubic to a quadratic.

1. **Hunt for a root:** $P(1) = -6$, $P(-1) = 12$, $P(3) = 54 - 27 - 33 + 6 = 0$. So $(x-3)$ is a factor.

   Using $P(a) = 0 \iff (x-a)$ is a factor

2. **Divide** (or match coefficients): $2x^3 - 3x^2 - 11x + 6 = (x-3)(2x^2 + 3x - 2)$.

   Using polynomial division

3. **Factorise the quadratic:** $2x^2 + 3x - 2 = (2x-1)(x+2)$.

   Using factorise the quadratic

✓ $P(x) = (x-3)(2x-1)(x+2)$, so $x = -2, \frac{1}{2}, 3$.

Worked example 2 **Two unknowns from two factors** 3 marks

$P(x) = x^3 + ax^2 + bx - 6$ has factors $(x - 1)$ and $(x + 2)$. Find a and b, then fully factorise $P(x)$.

Theory
Each known factor gives an equation: substituting its root into $P(x)$ must give zero. Two factors give two equations for the two unknowns.

1 $P(1) = 0$: $1 + a + b - 6 = 0 \Rightarrow a + b = 5$. — Using $P(1) = 0$

2 $P(-2) = 0$: $-8 + 4a - 2b - 6 = 0 \Rightarrow 2a - b = 7$. — Using $P(-2) = 0$

3 Add the equations: $3a = 12$, so $a = 4,\ b = 1$. — Using solve simultaneously

✓ $a = 4,\ b = 1$ and $P(x) = x^3 + 4x^2 + x - 6 = (x - 1)(x + 2)(x + 3)$. (The third factor must make the constant term -6: $(-1)(2)(c) = -6 \Rightarrow c = 3$.)

Sum and difference of cubes

$$a^3 + b^3 = (a + b)(a^2 - ab + b^2) \qquad a^3 - b^3 = (a - b)(a^2 + ab + b^2)$$

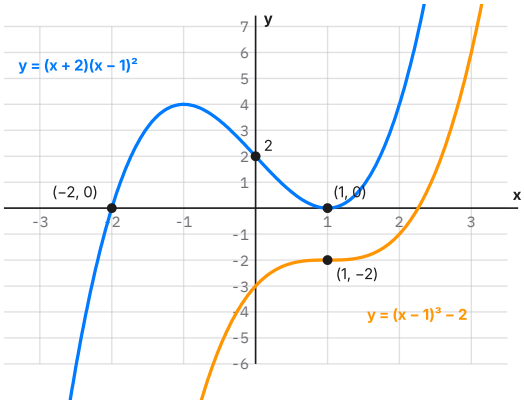
The quadratic factor never has real roots, so $x^3 - 27 = 0$ has only one real solution, $x = 3$.

Shapes of polynomial graphs

A factor tells you what the graph does at that x-intercept:

Factor	Behaviour at $x = a$
$(x - a)$	Cuts straight through the axis
$(x - a)^2$	Touches the axis and turns (a turning point on the axis)
$(x - a)^3$	Flattens out and passes through: a **stationary point of inflection**

End behaviour depends on the degree and the sign of the leading coefficient. Odd degree, positive: from bottom-left to top-right. Even degree, positive: both ends up. A negative leading coefficient flips everything.



$y = (x + 2)(x - 1)^2$ cuts at $x = -2$ and touches at $x = 1$. $y = (x - 1)^3 - 2$ is the basic cubic translated: its stationary point of inflection is at $(1, -2)$.

Cubic in "turning point" (inflection) form

$$y = a(x-h)^3 + k$$

Stationary point of inflection at (h, k). No other turning points.

Worked example 3 **Rule from a graph's features** 2 marks

A cubic touches the x-axis at $x = 2$, crosses it at $x = -1$ and passes through $(0, 8)$. Find its rule.

Theory

The shape at each x-intercept tells you the factor: a crossing gives $(x-p)$, a touch (turning point on the axis) gives $(x-q)^2$. One more point fixes the dilation factor a.

1 The touch gives a squared factor: $y = a(x+1)(x-2)^2$.

Using
touch at $q \Rightarrow (x-q)^2$

2 Substitute $(0, 8)$: $8 = a(1)(4)$, so $a = 2$.

Using
substitute a known point to find a

✓ $y = 2(x+1)(x-2)^2$ (expanded: $y = 2x^3 - 6x^2 + 8$).

Worked example 4 **Biquadratic (quartic in disguise)** 2 marks

Solve $x^4 - 5x^2 + 4 = 0$.

Theory

A quartic with only x^4 and x^2 terms is a quadratic in x^2. Substitute $u = x^2$, solve, then go back to x, rejecting any negative u.

1 Let $u = x^2$: $u^2 - 5u + 4 = 0 \Rightarrow (u-1)(u-4) = 0$, so $u = 1$ or $u = 4$.

Using
$u = x^2$

✓ $x = \pm 1, \pm 2$. Don't stop at u: the question asked for x.

Using
$x^2 = u \Rightarrow x = \pm\sqrt{u}$

How many solutions? Polynomials with a parameter

Exam 2 loves "find the values of k for which the equation has exactly one / two / three solutions". Rewrite so the parameter sits alone, then think of it as a horizontal line $y = k$ moving up and down against a fixed graph.

Worked example 5 **Number of solutions of $x^3 - 3x + k = 0$** 4 marks

Find the values of k for which $x^3 - 3x + k = 0$ has (a) exactly three, (b) exactly two, (c) exactly one real solution.

Theory

The number of solutions of $f(x) = c$ equals the number of times the horizontal line $y = c$ meets $y = f(x)$. The turning points mark where that count changes.

1. Rearrange: $-k = x^3 - 3x$. Count intersections of $y = x^3 - 3x$ with the horizontal line $y = -k$.

   Using: $f(x) = c \leftrightarrow$ intersections with $y = c$

2. $y = x^3 - 3x$ has turning points where $3x^2 - 3 = 0$, i.e. $x = \pm 1$: a local max at $(-1, 2)$ and a local min at $(1, -2)$.

   Using: $f'(x) = 0$ at turning points

3. The line cuts three times when it is strictly between the turning points: $-2 < -k < 2$, i.e. $-2 < k < 2$. It touches a turning point (two solutions) when $-k = \pm 2$.

✓ **(a) $-2 < k < 2$; (b) $k = \pm 2$; (c) $k < -2$ or $k > 2$.** Check (b): $k = 2$ gives $x^3 - 3x + 2 = (x - 1)^2(x + 2)$, two distinct solutions.

Worked example 6 **How many solutions? A difference of squares (hard)** 4 marks

Let $f(x) = (x^2 - 1)^2$ and $k > 0$. Find the number of solutions of $f(x) = k^2$ for each value of k.

Theory

Don't expand a quartic. Anything of the form $A^2 = B^2$ is a difference of squares, $(A - B)(A + B) = 0$, which splits into two easier equations. Count the solutions of each separately, and watch for values of the parameter where a solution count changes or two solutions coincide.

1. $(x^2 - 1)^2 - k^2 = 0 \Rightarrow (x^2 - 1 - k)(x^2 - 1 + k) = 0$, so $x^2 = 1 + k$ or $x^2 = 1 - k$.

   Using: $A^2 - B^2 = (A - B)(A + B)$

2. $x^2 = 1 + k$: since $k > 0$, $1 + k > 0$, giving always two solutions $x = \pm\sqrt{1 + k}$.

   Using: $x^2 = c$: 2 solutions if $c > 0$, 1 if $c = 0$, 0 if $c < 0$

3. $x^2 = 1 - k$: two solutions if $0 < k < 1$; one solution ($x = 0$) if $k = 1$; none if $k > 1$. The two equations never share a solution, because $1 + k \neq 1 - k$ for $k > 0$.

✓ **4 solutions for $0 < k < 1$; 3 solutions for $k = 1$; 2 solutions for $k > 1$** . Graphically: $y = (x^2 - 1)^2$ has minimums at $(\pm 1, 0)$ and a local maximum at $(0, 1)$. The line $y = k^2$ cuts four times below the maximum, touches it (3 solutions) when $k^2 = 1$, and cuts twice above it.

   Using: $f'(x) = 0$ at turning points

Trick alert: polynomial traps

- **"Solutions" means distinct solutions.** $(x-1)^2(x+2)=0$ has two solutions, not three.
- **A factor isn't always a root you can see.** If $(x-1)$ is a factor of x^3+x-2, the other factor x^2+x+2 has a negative discriminant, so the graph has only one x-intercept.
- **Remainder with $(x+a)$:** substitute $x=-a$, not $x=a$.
- **The turning point at a double root isn't always a minimum.** For $y=(x+1)^2(x-3)$ (positive leading coefficient) the double root is on the left, so it's a local *maximum*.

Summary

- Remainder of $P(x)\div(x-a)$ is $P(a)$; $(x-a)$ is a factor iff $P(a)=0$.
- Single factor: cut. Squared: touch and turn. Cubed: stationary point of inflection.
- Counting solutions with a parameter: isolate the parameter and slide a horizontal line past the turning points.
- Watch for quadratic factors with negative discriminants: they add no x-intercepts.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2024 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 17 — 27% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 9) ↗

Output of an algorithm that searches for integer roots of a cubic

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 9) ↗

Answer: D · A 14% · B 26% · C 32% · D 27%

The roots are 3, −3 and 2. The loop counts c down from 18, checking c then −c, so it prints 3, −3, 2.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 19 — 32% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 9) ↗

Values of k giving one positive and one negative root of a quadratic

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 9) ↗

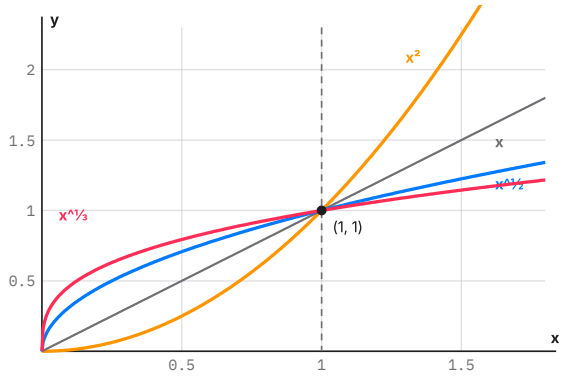
Answer: D · A 27% · B 11% · C 13% · D 32% · E 16%

Opposite signs need the product of the roots to be negative: $4k^2-\frac{9}{4}<0$, so $-\frac{3}{4}<k<\frac{3}{4}$.

Power functions, hyperbolas & root functions

The families at a glance

Rule	Name	Domain	Range	Key features
x^n, n even positive	even power (x^2, x^4)	$\mathbb{R}$	$[0, \infty)$	U-shaped, symmetric in the y-axis; flatter near 0 and steeper outside $[-1, 1]$ as n grows
x^n, n odd positive	odd power (x^3, x^5)	$\mathbb{R}$	$\mathbb{R}$	Stationary point of inflection at the origin, point-symmetric
$x^{-1} = \frac{1}{x}$	hyperbola	$\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$	$\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$	Asymptotes $x = 0,\ y = 0$; branches in quadrants 1 and 3
$x^{-2} = \frac{1}{x^2}$	truncus	$\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$	$(0, \infty)$	Both branches above the x-axis
$x^{1/2} = \sqrt{x}$	square root	$[0, \infty)$	$[0, \infty)$	Starts at the origin (an endpoint), increasing
$x^{1/3} = \sqrt[3]{x}$	cube root	$\mathbb{R}$	$\mathbb{R}$	Vertical tangent at the origin
$x^{2/3} = (\sqrt[3]{x})^2$	“seagull”	$\mathbb{R}$	$[0, \infty)$	Sharp cusp at the origin



On $(0, 1)$ the order flips: $x^{1/3} > x^{1/2} > x > x^2$. On $(1, \infty)$ it's the other way round. Every power function passes through $(1, 1)$.

Transformed forms

Hyperbola, truncus and root in transformed form

$$y = \frac{a}{x - h} + k \qquad y = \frac{a}{(x - h)^2} + k \qquad y = a\sqrt{\pm(x - h)} + k$$

For the hyperbola and truncus: asymptotes $x = h$ and $y = k$. For the root: the endpoint is (h, k).

Key idea

For every sketch, find: (1) asymptotes or endpoint, (2) the y-intercept (put $x = 0$), (3) the x-intercept(s) (put $y = 0$), (4) the domain and range. The sign of a tells you which way the branches go.

Worked example 1 **Sketching a hyperbola** 3 marks

Sketch $y = \dfrac{2}{x-1} + 3$, labelling asymptotes and intercepts.

Theory

In $y = \dfrac{a}{x-h} + k$, the vertical asymptote is where the denominator is zero and the horizontal asymptote is the value y approaches for large $|x|$. The sign of a decides which quadrants the branches sit in.

1 **Asymptotes:** $x = 1$ and $y = 3$.

Using $y = \dfrac{a}{x-h} + k:\ x = h, y = k$

2 y**-intercept:** $y = \frac{2}{-1} + 3 = 1$, so $(0, 1)$.

Using $x = 0$ for the y-intercept

3 x**-intercept:** $0 = \frac{2}{x-1} + 3 \Rightarrow x - 1 = -\frac{2}{3} \Rightarrow x = \frac{1}{3}$.

Using $y = 0$ for the x-intercept

Since $a = 2 > 0$, the branches sit top-right and bottom-left of the asymptote intersection $(1, 3)$. **Asymptotes** $x = 1,\ y = 3$**; intercepts** $(0, 1)$ **and** $(\frac{1}{3}, 0)$. Domain $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{1\}$, range $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{3\}$.

Worked example 2 **Sketching a truncus** 3 marks

Find the intercepts, asymptotes and range of $y = -\dfrac{1}{(x+2)^2} + 4$.

Theory

A truncus $y = \dfrac{a}{(x-h)^2} + k$ has both branches on the same side of the horizontal asymptote, because the squared denominator is always positive. $a < 0$ puts them below.

1 Asymptotes $x = -2$, $y = 4$. $a < 0$, so both branches are *below* $y = 4$.

Using $y = \dfrac{a}{(x-h)^2} + k:\ x = h, y = k$

2 y-intercept: $-\frac{1}{4} + 4 = \frac{15}{4}$.

Using $x = 0$

3 x-intercepts: $(x+2)^2 = \frac{1}{4} \Rightarrow x + 2 = \pm\frac{1}{2} \Rightarrow x = -\frac{5}{2}, -\frac{3}{2}$.

Using $y = 0$

Intercepts $(-\frac{5}{2}, 0), (-\frac{3}{2}, 0), (0, \frac{15}{4})$**; range** $(-\infty, 4)$.

Worked example 3 **A reflected square root** 3 marks

Sketch $y = 2\sqrt{3-x} - 4$, stating the domain, range and intercepts.

Theory
$\sqrt{-(x-h)}$ is the square-root graph reflected in the y-axis, so it starts at (h, k) and extends to the left. The domain comes from requiring a non-negative argument.

1 Rewrite as $y = 2\sqrt{-(x-3)} - 4$: reflected in the y-axis, so the graph goes *left* from the endpoint $(3, -4)$. Domain: $3 - x \geq 0 \Rightarrow x \leq 3$.

Using
$\sqrt{u}$ needs $u \geq 0$

2 x-intercept: $\sqrt{3-x} = 2 \Rightarrow 3 - x = 4 \Rightarrow x = -1$. y-intercept: $2\sqrt{3} - 4 \approx -0.54$.

Using
$y = 0$ and $x = 0$

Domain $(-\infty, 3]$, range $[-4, \infty)$; intercepts $(-1, 0)$ and $(0, 2\sqrt{3} - 4)$.

Worked example 4 **Finding a rule from asymptotes and a point** 2 marks

A truncus has asymptotes $x = -1$ and $y = 2$ and passes through $(0, 5)$. Find its rule.

Theory
The asymptotes give h and k directly; a single point on the graph then determines a.

1 $y = \dfrac{a}{(x+1)^2} + 2$. Substitute $(0, 5)$: $5 = a + 2$.

Using
$y = \dfrac{a}{(x-h)^2} + k$

$a = 3$, so $y = \dfrac{3}{(x+1)^2} + 2$.

Trick alert: power function traps

- **Cube roots of negatives exist.** $x^{1/3}$ and $x^{2/3}$ have domain $\mathbb{R}$. CAS sometimes shows only the $x \geq 0$ half. Don't trust it blindly.
- $x^{2/3} = 4$ **has two solutions:** $x^{1/3} = \pm 2$, so $x = \pm 8$.
- **Asymptotes are not in the range.** $y = \frac{a}{x-h} + k$ never equals k.
- $\sqrt{3-x}$ **goes left**, not right. Factor out the negative to see the reflection.

Summary

- Hyperbola $\frac{a}{x-h} + k$ and truncus $\frac{a}{(x-h)^2} + k$: asymptotes $x = h$, $y = k$.
- Root functions start at an endpoint; factor out a negative inside the root to spot a reflection.
- $x^{1/3}$ and $x^{2/3}$ are defined for all real x.
- Between 0 and 1 the powers swap order; all pass through $(1, 1)$.

Transformations of graphs

The three moves

Transformation	Mapping	Effect on the rule $y = f(x)$
Dilation by factor a **from the x-axis** (parallel to the y-axis)	$(x, y) \to (x, ay)$	$y = af(x)$
Dilation by factor b **from the y-axis** (parallel to the x-axis)	$(x, y) \to (bx, y)$	$y = f\left(\frac{x}{b}\right)$
Reflection in the x-axis	$(x, y) \to (x, -y)$	$y = -f(x)$
Reflection in the y-axis	$(x, y) \to (-x, y)$	$y = f(-x)$
Translation h right and k up	$(x, y) \to (x + h, y + k)$	$y = f(x - h) + k$

"From the x-axis" means vertical

A dilation *from* the x-axis pushes points away from the x-axis, so it stretches vertically. VCAA also writes "parallel to the y-axis" for the same thing. Mix these up and every mark in the question goes.

The general form, and the order that works

Standard form

$$y = a\, f\big(n(x - h)\big) + k$$

Read it as: dilate by $|a|$ from the x-axis (reflect in the x-axis if $a < 0$); dilate by $\frac{1}{|n|}$ from the y-axis (reflect in the y-axis if $n < 0$); *then* translate h right and k up. The mapping is $(x, y) \to \left(\frac{x}{n} + h,\ ay + k\right)$.

Key idea

Always factor out the coefficient of x first. $f(2x + 6) = f(2(x + 3))$ is a translation of 3 left, not 6, when the dilation is done first. With dilations first and translations last you never go wrong.

Finding the image equation: the dash method

This is the method VCAA's solutions use, and it works for any transformation (even ones you can't picture):

1. Write the mapping as $x' = \ldots$ and $y' = \ldots$.
2. Rearrange to get x and y in terms of x' and y'.
3. Substitute into the original rule, then drop the dashes.

Worked example 1 **Image of a square-root graph** 2 marks

Find the image of $y = \sqrt{x}$ under the transformation $(x, y) \to (-2x + 1,\ 3y - 2)$.

Theory

To find an image rule, write the old coordinates in terms of the new ones, then substitute into the original equation. This works for any combination of dilations, reflections and translations.

1 $x' = -2x + 1 \Rightarrow x = \dfrac{1 - x'}{2}$, and $y' = 3y - 2 \Rightarrow y = \dfrac{y' + 2}{3}$.

Using $x' = ax + b \Rightarrow x = \dfrac{x' - b}{a}$

2 Substitute into $y = \sqrt{x}$: $\dfrac{y' + 2}{3} = \sqrt{\dfrac{1 - x'}{2}}$.

Using substitute into $y = f(x)$

✓ $y = 3\sqrt{\dfrac{1 - x}{2}} - 2$, with domain $x \leq 1$.

Worked example 2 **Describing a sequence of transformations** 3 marks

Describe a sequence of transformations that maps $y = e^x$ onto $y = 3e^{2x-4} + 1$, and give the mapping.

Theory

Write the image as $y = af(n(x - h)) + k$: a dilates from the x-axis, n dilates from the y-axis by factor $\frac{1}{n}$, and h, k translate. Factor the coefficient of x out of the bracket first.

1 Factor the exponent: $y = 3e^{2(x-2)} + 1$. So $a = 3,\ n = 2,\ h = 2,\ k = 1$.

Using $y = af(n(x - h)) + k$

2 Dilation by factor 3 from the x-axis; dilation by factor $\frac{1}{2}$ from the y-axis; translation 2 units right and 1 unit up.

Using dilate, then translate

✓ **Mapping** $(x, y) \to \left(\frac{x}{2} + 2,\ 3y + 1\right)$. Check with the dash method: $x = 2x' - 4$, $y = \frac{y'-1}{3}$, giving $\frac{y'-1}{3} = e^{2x'-4}$. ✓

Using $(x, y) \to \left(\dfrac{x}{n} + h,\ ay + k\right)$

Worked example 3 **Transforming a point, domain and range** 3 marks

The function f has domain $[-2, 4]$ and range $[0, 6]$, and $f(2) = 5$. For $g(x) = -f(2x) + 3$, find (a) the domain and range of g, and (b) the image of the point $(2, 5)$.

Theory

Transform the domain by solving for where the inside of f is allowed; transform the range by applying the outside operations in order. Points map using the same rule.

1 **Domain:** need $2x \in [-2, 4]$, so $x \in [-1, 2]$.

Using $2x \in \text{dom} f$

2 **Range:** $f \in [0, 6] \Rightarrow -f \in [-6, 0] \Rightarrow -f + 3 \in [-3, 3]$.

Using apply $-f + 3$ to the range

3 **Point:** the mapping is $(x, y) \to \left(\frac{x}{2},\ -y + 3\right)$, so $(2, 5) \to (1, -2)$.

Using $(x, y) \to \left(\frac{x}{2},\ -y + 3\right)$

Domain $[-1, 2]$, range $[-3, 3]$; image point $(1, -2)$. Check: $g(1) = -f(2) + 3 = -5 + 3 = -2$. ✓

Trick alert: transformation traps

- **Horizontal changes act "backwards".** $f(x - 3)$ moves right 3; $f(2x)$ squashes by factor $\frac{1}{2}$ (dilation factor $\frac{1}{2}$ from the y-axis, not 2).
- **Order matters when dilations and translations mix.** "Translate 1 right, then dilate by 2 from the y-axis" gives $f\left(\frac{x}{2} - 1\right)$, not $f\left(\frac{x-1}{2}\right)$.
- **Sequences aren't unique.** $y = (2x)^2 = 4x^2$: a dilation by $\frac{1}{2}$ from the y-axis gives the same graph as a dilation by 4 from the x-axis. Similarly $e^{x-2} = e^{-2}e^{x}$.
- **Transform the asymptotes too.** The image of $y = \log_e x$ under a translation 3 left has asymptote $x = -3$.

Summary

- $y = af(n(x - h)) + k$: mapping $(x, y) \to \left(\frac{x}{n} + h,\ ay + k\right)$.
- "From the x-axis" = vertical; "from the y-axis" = horizontal.
- Dash method: express x, y in terms of x', y' and substitute.
- Domains, ranges, points and asymptotes all transform with the graph.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2025 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 20 36% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 12) ↗

Which transformation sequence does not map a^x to a^{2x+2}

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 12) ↗

Answer: C · A 24% · B 18% · C 36% · D 21%

Apply each sequence in order. The sequence "dilate by a from the x-axis, dilate by ½ from the y-axis, then translate 1 right" gives a^{2x-1}.

2025 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 15 44% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 9) ↗

Image of the point (1, 3) on $y = 1 - g(2x - 3)$

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 9) ↗

Answer: B · A 25% · B 44% · C 22% · D 8%

You need $2x - 3 = 1$, so $x = 2$ and $y = 1 - 3 = -2$.

Exponential & logarithmic functions

Laws you must know cold

Index laws

$$a^m a^n = a^{m+n} \quad \frac{a^m}{a^n} = a^{m-n} \quad (a^m)^n = a^{mn} \quad a^0 = 1 \quad a^{-n} = \frac{1}{a^n}$$

Log laws ($a, x, y > 0,\ a \neq 1$)

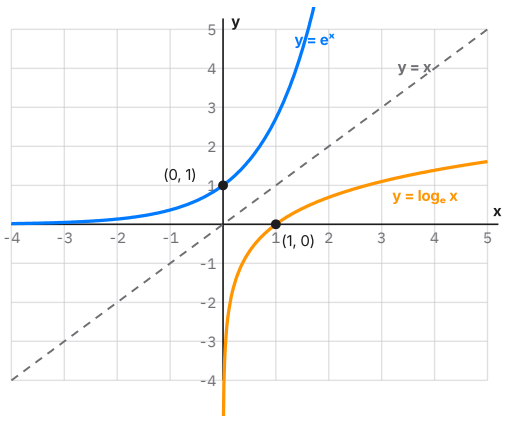
$$\log_a(xy) = \log_a x + \log_a y \quad \log_a \frac{x}{y} = \log_a x - \log_a y \quad \log_a x^n = n \log_a x$$

Definition and inverse pair

$$y = a^x \iff x = \log_a y \qquad e^{\log_e x} = x\ (x > 0) \qquad \log_e(e^x) = x$$

$\log_e$ is written $\ln$ on most calculators. Change of base: $\log_a x = \dfrac{\log_e x}{\log_e a}$.

Graphs



$y = e^x$ and $y = \log_e x$ are inverses: each is the reflection of the other in $y = x$. e^x has horizontal asymptote $y = 0$ and passes through $(0, 1)$; $\log_e x$ has vertical asymptote $x = 0$ and passes through $(1, 0)$.

Worked example 1 **Sketching a transformed log graph** — 3 marks

For $y = 2\log_e(3 - x)$, state the maximal domain and the asymptote, and find the axis intercepts.

Theory

A log is only defined for positive arguments, which gives the domain and a vertical asymptote where the argument is zero. The log equals zero when its argument equals 1.

1. Need $3 - x > 0$: domain $(-\infty, 3)$, asymptote $x = 3$. It's reflected in the y-axis, so the graph rises to the *left*.

   Using $\log_e u$ needs $u > 0$

2. x-intercept: $\log_e(3 - x) = 0 \Rightarrow 3 - x = 1 \Rightarrow x = 2$.

   Using $\log_e 1 = 0$

✓ **Domain $(-\infty, 3)$, asymptote $x = 3$, intercepts $(2, 0)$ and $(0, 2\log_e 3)$.**

Solving equations

Worked example 2 **Hidden quadratic in e^x (tech-free classic)** 3 marks

Solve $e^{2x} - 5e^x + 6 = 0$.

Theory
$e^{2x} = (e^x)^2$, so the equation is a quadratic in e^x. Solve for e^x, reject negative values ($e^x > 0$), then take logs.

1 Let $u = e^x$, so $e^{2x} = u^2$: $u^2 - 5u + 6 = 0 \Rightarrow (u-2)(u-3) = 0$.

Using
$u = e^x,\ e^{2x} = u^2$

2 $e^x = 2$ or $e^x = 3$.

✓ $x = \log_e 2$ **or** $x = \log_e 3$. (If a factor gave $e^x = -1$, you'd reject it: $e^x > 0$.)

Using
$e^x = a \iff x = \log_e a$

Worked example 3 **Log equation with a rejected solution** 3 marks

Solve $\log_2 x + \log_2(x-2) = 3$.

Theory
Combine logs of the same base into a single log, then convert to index form. Always check solutions in the original equation, because logs of negatives are undefined.

1 Combine: $\log_2\big(x(x-2)\big) = 3 \Rightarrow x^2 - 2x = 2^3 = 8$.

Using
$\log_a m + \log_a n = \log_a(mn)$,
$\log_a x = y \iff x = a^y$

2 $x^2 - 2x - 8 = 0 \Rightarrow (x-4)(x+2) = 0$, so $x = 4$ or $x = -2$.

Using
null factor law

✓ $x = 4$ **only.** $x = -2$ makes $\log_2 x$ undefined in the original equation. Checking the original equation is worth a mark.

Using
reject values outside the domain

Worked example 4 **Different bases** 2 marks

Solve $2^x = 3^{x-1}$, giving an exact answer.

Theory
When the bases differ, take the log of both sides and use the power law to bring the unknown down from the index; then solve the linear equation.

1 Take $\log_e$ of both sides: $x \log_e 2 = (x-1)\log_e 3$.

Using
$\log_e(a^x) = x \log_e a$

2 $x(\log_e 3 - \log_e 2) = \log_e 3$.

Using
collect x terms

✓ $x = \dfrac{\log_e 3}{\log_e\left(\frac{3}{2}\right)} \approx 2.71$.

Using
$\log_e a - \log_e b = \log_e \dfrac{a}{b}$

Worked example 5 **Finding an inverse** 3 marks

Find the inverse of $f(x) = 2e^{x-1} + 3$, stating its domain.

Theory

To find an inverse, swap x and y and make y the subject. The inverse's domain is the original function's range.

1 Swap: $x = 2e^{y-1} + 3 \Rightarrow e^{y-1} = \dfrac{x-3}{2}$.

Using

swap x and y

2 $y - 1 = \log_e\left(\dfrac{x-3}{2}\right)$.

Using

$e^u = v \iff u = \log_e v$

✓ $f^{-1}(x) = \log_e\left(\dfrac{x-3}{2}\right) + 1$, with domain = range of f = $(3, \infty)$.

Using

$\text{dom} f^{-1} = \text{ran} f$

Growth and decay models

Exponential model

$$A = A_0 e^{kt}$$

$k > 0$: growth; $k < 0$: decay. Half-life (decay) $= \dfrac{\log_e 2}{|k|}$.

Worked example 6 **Newton's law of cooling (Exam 2 style)** 4 marks

A cup of coffee cools according to $T = 20 + 70e^{-kt}$ (°C, t in minutes). After 10 minutes it is 55 °C. (a) Find k exactly. (b) How long until it reaches 30 °C?

Theory

Exponential models are solved by isolating the exponential term, then taking logs to bring the unknown down.

1 (a) $55 = 20 + 70e^{-10k} \Rightarrow e^{-10k} = \frac{1}{2} \Rightarrow k = \dfrac{\log_e 2}{10}$.

Using

$e^u = v \iff u = \log_e v$

2 (b) $30 = 20 + 70e^{-kt} \Rightarrow e^{-kt} = \frac{1}{7} \Rightarrow t = \dfrac{\log_e 7}{k} = \dfrac{10 \log_e 7}{\log_e 2}$.

Using

$e^u = v \iff u = \log_e v$

✓ **(a) $k = \frac{\log_e 2}{10} \approx 0.0693$; (b) $t \approx 28.1$ minutes.** The long-run temperature is 20 °C (room temperature), the horizontal asymptote.

Trick alert: exp and log traps

- $e^x = 0$ **has no solution.** In $e^{2x} = 3e^x$, divide by e^x (it's never 0): $x = \log_e 3$ only.
- $\log_e(x^2) = 2$ **has two solutions** ($x = \pm e$), but $2\log_e x = 2$ has one ($x = e$). Log laws quietly change domains.
- $\log_e(a + b) \neq \log_e a + \log_e b$. The product law is for products only.
- $\log_e(2x) = \log_e 2 + \log_e x$: a horizontal dilation of a log graph is the same as a vertical translation.

Summary

- e^x and $\log_e x$ are inverses: domain and range swap; asymptotes $y = 0$ and $x = 0$ swap.
- Hidden quadratics: let $u = e^x$ (or 2^x), solve, reject impossible values.
- After combining logs, check every solution in the original equation.
- Models: find k from one data point, then use it.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2024 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 6

state average 38% of marks

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Solve $2\log_3(x-4) + \log_3(x) = 2$

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 7) ↗

Solve for x (4 marks · state average 1.5 / 4, 38%)

- Combines: $\log_3\left(x(x-4)^2\right) = 2$
- $x^3 - 8x^2 + 16x - 9 = 0$
- Factorises: $(x-1)(x^2 - 7x + 9) = 0$
- Only $x = \frac{7+\sqrt{13}}{2}$ satisfies $x > 4$

Answer / notes: $x = \frac{7+\sqrt{13}}{2}$. Reject $x = 1$ and $\frac{7-\sqrt{13}}{2}$ because the log needs x > 4.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section B · Question 3

state average 44% of marks

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$g(x) = 2^x + 5$: limit, derivative, tangents through the origin; $h(x) = 2^x - x^2$: inflection, decreasing interval, Newton's method

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a. $\lim_{x\to-\infty} g(x)$ (1 mark · state average 0.7 / 1, 70%)

- 5

Answer / notes: 5

b. k with $g'(x) = k \times 2^x$ (1 mark · state average 0.9 / 1, 90%)

- $k = \log_e 2$

Answer / notes: $k = \log_e 2$

c.i. Tangent at $(a, g(a))$ (1 mark · state average 0.5 / 1, 50%)

- $y = 2^a \log_e 2\,(x - a) + 2^a + 5$

Answer / notes: Point–gradient form.

c.ii. Tangent to g through the origin (3 d.p.) (2 marks · state average 0.6 / 2, 30%)

- Sets $0 = -a\,2^a \log_e 2 + 2^a + 5$, giving $a \approx 2.618$
- $y \approx 4.255x$

Answer / notes: Substitute (0, 0) into the general tangent, solve for a, then find the gradient.

d. Point of inflection of h (2 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.6 / 1, 60%)

- $\approx (2.06, -0.07)$

Answer / notes: $h''(x) = (\log_e 2)^2 2^x - 2 = 0$

e. Largest interval on which h is strictly decreasing (2 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.4 / 1, 40%)

- $[0.49, 3.21]$

Answer / notes: Between the two roots of h′, with square brackets (the endpoints are included).

f. Newton's method from $x_0 = 0$: x_1, x_2, x_3 (3 d.p.) (2 marks · state average 1.2 / 2, 60%)

- $x_1 \approx -1.443$
- $x_2 \approx -0.897,\ x_3 \approx -0.773$

Answer / notes: −1.443, −0.897, −0.773

g. Why a solution of $\log_e(2)2^x - 2x = 0$ is a bad starting point (1 mark · state average 0.2 / 1, 20%)

- That equation is $h'(x) = 0$, so the tangent is horizontal and Newton's formula divides by zero

Answer / notes: A stationary point makes the tangent horizontal, so it never meets the x-axis.

h. Positive n for which $n^x - x^n$ has a local minimum on the x-axis (2 marks · state average 0.2 / 2, 10%)

- Requires $f(x) = 0$ and $f'(x) = 0$ at the same x, giving $x = \frac{n}{\log_e n}$
- $n = e$

Answer / notes: $n = e$: the curve $e^x - x^e$ touches the axis at x = e. An exact answer was required.

Circular (trigonometric) functions

Radians, exact values and symmetry

π radians $= 180°$. On the unit circle, the point at angle θ is $(\cos\theta, \sin\theta)$, and $\tan\theta = \frac{\sin\theta}{\cos\theta}$.

θ	0	$\frac{\pi}{6}$	$\frac{\pi}{4}$	$\frac{\pi}{3}$	$\frac{\pi}{2}$
$\sin\theta$	0	$\frac{1}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$	1
$\cos\theta$	1	$\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$	$\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$	$\frac{1}{2}$	0
$\tan\theta$	0	$\frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}$	1	$\sqrt{3}$	undefined

Symmetry (quadrants 2, 3, 4)

$$\sin(\pi-\theta)=\sin\theta \quad \sin(\pi+\theta)=-\sin\theta \quad \sin(2\pi-\theta)=-\sin\theta$$

$$\cos(\pi-\theta)=-\cos\theta \quad \cos(\pi+\theta)=-\cos\theta \quad \cos(2\pi-\theta)=\cos\theta$$

$$\sin\left(\tfrac{\pi}{2}-\theta\right)=\cos\theta \qquad \sin^2\theta+\cos^2\theta=1$$

Memory aid for the positive ratio in each quadrant, going anticlockwise from quadrant 1: **A**ll, **S**in, **T**an, **C**os.

Graphs

Transformed sine and cosine

$$y = a\sin\big(n(x-h)\big)+k$$

Amplitude $|a|$, period $\frac{2\pi}{n}$, horizontal shift h, centre line $y=k$, range $[k-|a|,\ k+|a|]$. For $y=a\tan(n(x-h))+k$: period $\frac{\pi}{n}$, with vertical asymptotes wherever $n(x-h)=\frac{\pi}{2}+m\pi$.

Worked example 1 **Sketch over a restricted domain** 4 marks

Sketch $y=2\sin\left(2x-\frac{\pi}{3}\right)+1$ for $x\in[0,\pi]$, labelling endpoints and x-intercepts with exact coordinates.

Theory

Write the rule in the form $a\sin(n(x-h))+k$ to read off amplitude, period, horizontal shift and centre line. For intercepts, solve over the transformed interval of the argument.

1 Factor: $y=2\sin\left(2\left(x-\frac{\pi}{6}\right)\right)+1$. Amplitude 2, period π, shifted $\frac{\pi}{6}$ right, centre $y=1$, range $[-1,3]$.

Using

$\text{period}=\frac{2\pi}{n}$, range $=[k-|a|, k+|a|]$

2 Endpoints: $y(0)=2\sin\left(-\frac{\pi}{3}\right)+1=1-\sqrt{3}$; $y(\pi)=2\sin\left(\frac{5\pi}{3}\right)+1=1-\sqrt{3}$.

Using

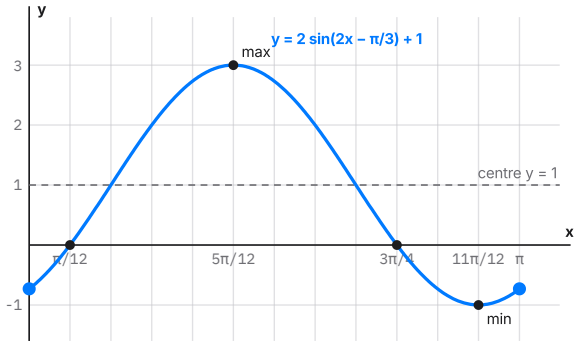
substitute the endpoints

3 x-intercepts: $\sin\left(2x-\frac{\pi}{3}\right)=-\frac{1}{2}$. With $2x-\frac{\pi}{3}\in\left[-\frac{\pi}{3},\frac{5\pi}{3}\right]$: $2x-\frac{\pi}{3}=-\frac{\pi}{6}$ or $\frac{7\pi}{6}$.

Using

$\sin\theta=-\frac{1}{2}\Rightarrow\theta=-\frac{\pi}{6},\frac{7\pi}{6},\ldots$

✓ **Endpoints $(0,1-\sqrt{3})$ and $(\pi,1-\sqrt{3})$; x-intercepts $\left(\frac{\pi}{12},0\right)$ and $\left(\frac{3\pi}{4},0\right)$**; maximum $\left(\frac{5\pi}{12},3\right)$, minimum $\left(\frac{11\pi}{12},-1\right)$.



$y = 2\sin\left(2x - \frac{\pi}{3}\right) + 1$ on $[0, \pi]$. Always find where the argument $2x - \frac{\pi}{3}$ starts and ends. That's the step that finds all the solutions.

Solving trig equations

1. Isolate the trig function: $\sin(\ldots) = c$.
2. **Adjust the domain** to match the argument (e.g. $x \in [0, 2\pi] \Rightarrow 2x \in [0, 4\pi]$).
3. Find the reference angle from $|c|$, then use the quadrants for the sign.
4. List every solution in the adjusted domain, then solve for x.

Worked example 2 **A double-angle argument** 3 marks

Solve $2\cos(2x) + \sqrt{2} = 0$ for $x \in [0, 2\pi]$.

Theory
Find the reference angle, use the quadrant rules (the sign of cos) to list angles, and extend the interval to match the argument: if $x \in [0, 2\pi]$ then $2x \in [0, 4\pi]$.

1 $\cos(2x) = -\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$. Reference angle $\frac{\pi}{4}$; cosine is negative in quadrants 2 and 3.

Using
$\cos\theta < 0$ in quadrants 2 and 3

2 $2x \in [0, 4\pi]$: $2x = \frac{3\pi}{4}, \frac{5\pi}{4}, \frac{11\pi}{4}, \frac{13\pi}{4}$.

Using
$x \in [0, 2\pi] \Rightarrow 2x \in [0, 4\pi]$

✓ $x = \frac{3\pi}{8}, \frac{5\pi}{8}, \frac{11\pi}{8}, \frac{13\pi}{8}$. A doubled argument means twice as many solutions. Four, not two.

Worked example 3 **sin = cos, and general solutions** 3 marks

(a) Solve $\sin(2x) = \cos(2x)$ for $x \in [0, \pi]$. (b) Find the general solution of $\sqrt{3}\sin(2x) = \cos(2x)$.

Theory
When sin and cos of the same angle are equal (or in a fixed ratio), divide to get tan. Tan repeats every π, which gives the general solution.

1 (a) Divide by $\cos(2x)$: $\tan(2x) = 1$. $2x \in [0, 2\pi]$: $2x = \frac{\pi}{4}, \frac{5\pi}{4}$, so $x = \frac{\pi}{8}, \frac{5\pi}{8}$.

Using
$\tan\theta = \dfrac{\sin\theta}{\cos\theta}$

2 (b) $\tan(2x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}$, so $2x = \frac{\pi}{6} + n\pi$, $n \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Using
$\tan\theta = a \Rightarrow \theta = \tan^{-1} a + n\pi$

✓ **(a)** $x = \frac{\pi}{8}, \frac{5\pi}{8}$; **(b)** $x = \frac{\pi}{12} + \frac{n\pi}{2}$, $n \in \mathbb{Z}$.

General solutions ($n \in \mathbb{Z}$)

$$\sin x = a: \ x = 2n\pi + \sin^{-1} a \ \text{ or } \ x = (2n+1)\pi - \sin^{-1} a$$

$$\cos x = a: \ x = 2n\pi \pm \cos^{-1} a \qquad \tan x = a: \ x = n\pi + \tan^{-1} a$$

Periodic models

Worked example 4 **Tide model (Exam 2 style)** 4 marks

The depth of water in a harbour is $D(t) = 3 + 2\cos\left(\frac{\pi t}{6}\right)$ metres, t hours after midnight. (a) State the maximum and minimum depths and the period. (b) For how long in the first 12 hours is the depth at least 4 m?

Theory

For $k + a\cos(nt)$, the maximum and minimum are $k \pm |a|$ and the period is $2\pi/n$. Inequalities are solved like equations, then you pick the intervals where the condition holds.

1 (a) Max $3 + 2 = 5$ m, min $3 - 2 = 1$ m, period $\frac{2\pi}{\pi/6} = 12$ hours.

Using

$\max = k + |a|$, $\min = k - |a|$, $\text{period} = \dfrac{2\pi}{n}$

2 (b) $\cos\left(\frac{\pi t}{6}\right) \geq \frac{1}{2}$ with $\frac{\pi t}{6} \in [0, 2\pi]$: $\frac{\pi t}{6} \in \left[0, \frac{\pi}{3}\right] \cup \left[\frac{5\pi}{3}, 2\pi\right]$.

Using

$\cos\theta = \frac{1}{2} \Rightarrow \theta = \frac{\pi}{3}, \frac{5\pi}{3}$

3 So $t \in [0, 2] \cup [10, 12]$.

(a) 5 m, 1 m, 12 h. (b) 4 hours in total (midnight to 2 am and 10 am to noon).

Trick alert: trig traps

- **Adjust the domain for the argument.** Forgetting this is the number-one way students lose solutions.
- $\sin^2 x = \frac{1}{4}$ **means** $\sin x = \pm\frac{1}{2}$: four solutions in $[0, 2\pi]$, not two.
- **Endpoints count.** $\sin x = 0$ on $[0, 2\pi]$ has three solutions: $0, \pi, 2\pi$.
- **Calculator in radians!** Degree mode is an instant zero in Methods.
- **Tan's period is** $\frac{\pi}{n}$, not $\frac{2\pi}{n}$.

Summary

- $y = a\sin(n(x-h)) + k$: amplitude $|a|$, period $\frac{2\pi}{n}$ (tan: $\frac{\pi}{n}$), range $[k - |a|, k + |a|]$.
- Solve: isolate, adjust the domain for the argument, reference angle, quadrants, then solve for x.
- General solutions: cos: $2n\pi \pm \alpha$; tan: $n\pi + \alpha$.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 18 29% correct

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Number of local minima of $\sin(ax)$ on $[-a\pi, a\pi]$

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 9) ↗

Answer: E · A 12% · B 9% · C 22% · D 26% · E 29%

Interval length $2a\pi$ ÷ period $\frac{2\pi}{a}$ = a^2 periods, each with one minimum.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 9

42% correct

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Value of a that makes a tan/sin hybrid continuous and smooth at x = 2π

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 5) ↗

Answer: C · A 7% · B 9% · C 42% · D 31% · E 10%

Continuity needs $\sin(2\pi a) = 0$. Smoothness needs $a\cos(2\pi a) = \frac{1}{2}$ (the gradient of $\tan\frac{x}{2}$ there). So $a = -\frac{1}{2}$.

Composite, inverse & combined functions

Combining functions

For $f+g$, $f-g$ and $f\times g$, the domain is the **intersection** of the two domains: $\text{dom}(f+g)=\text{dom}f\cap\text{dom}g$. To sketch $y=f(x)+g(x)$ by **addition of ordinates**, add the heights of the two graphs at key x-values (intercepts, asymptotes, where one graph is zero).

Composite functions

Composite

$$(f\circ g)(x)=f\big(g(x)\big)$$

$f\circ g$ exists if and only if $\text{ran}\,g\subseteq\text{dom}\,f$. Then $\text{dom}(f\circ g)=\text{dom}\,g$.

Key idea

Think of g as the first machine and f as the second. Every output of g must be an acceptable input for f. If it isn't, restrict the domain of g until it is.

Worked example 1 **Does the composite exist?** 4 marks

Let $f(x)=\sqrt{x}$ (maximal domain) and $g:\mathbb{R}\to\mathbb{R},\ g(x)=x^2-4$. (a) Explain why $f\circ g$ does not exist. (b) Find the maximal domain of g for which $f\circ g$ exists. (c) Does $g\circ f$ exist? If so, state its rule and domain.

Theory

$f\circ g$ means apply g first, so every output of g must be a valid input for f: the range of g must fit inside the domain of f.

1. (a) $\text{ran}\,g=[-4,\infty)$ but $\text{dom}\,f=[0,\infty)$. Since $[-4,\infty)\not\subseteq[0,\infty)$, $f\circ g$ does not exist.

   Using $f\circ g$ exists $\iff$ ran $g\subseteq$ dom f

2. (b) Need $g(x)\geq 0$: $x^2\geq 4\Rightarrow x\leq -2$ or $x\geq 2$.

   Using $g(x)\geq 0$

3. (c) $\text{ran}\,f=[0,\infty)\subseteq\mathbb{R}=\text{dom}\,g$, so yes. $g(f(x))=(\sqrt{x})^2-4=x-4$, with domain $=\text{dom}\,f=[0,\infty)$.

   Using $\text{dom}(g\circ f)=\text{dom}\ f$

(b) $(-\infty,-2]\cup[2,\infty)$. **(c)** $g\circ f(x)=x-4$, **domain** $[0,\infty)$. It's not the whole line $y=x-4$: it's only the part with $x\geq 0$.

Inverse functions

Only **one-to-one** functions have inverse functions. To find f^{-1}: swap x and y, make y the subject, and pick the correct branch using the range of f^{-1}.

Inverse facts

$$\text{dom}\,f^{-1}=\text{ran}\,f\qquad \text{ran}\,f^{-1}=\text{dom}\,f\qquad f\big(f^{-1}(x)\big)=x$$

The graph of f^{-1} is the reflection of f in the line $y=x$.

Worked example 2 **Restrict, then invert** 4 marks

Let $f:(-\infty, a] \to \mathbb{R},\ f(x) = (x-2)^2 - 3$. (a) Find the largest value of a for which f^{-1} exists. (b) With this a, find f^{-1} and its domain.

Theory

Only one-to-one functions have inverses, so a parabola must be restricted to one side of its turning point. The inverse's range is the original domain, which tells you which square root to keep.

1 (a) The turning point is at $x = 2$. To the left of it, f is one-to-one (decreasing). So $a = 2$.

Using

restrict to one side of the turning point

2 (b) Swap: $x = (y-2)^2 - 3 \Rightarrow (y-2)^2 = x + 3 \Rightarrow y - 2 = \pm\sqrt{x+3}$.

Using

swap x and y

3 The range of f^{-1} is the domain of f: $y \leq 2$. So take the **negative** root.

Using

ran f^{-1} = dom f

✓ $a = 2$; $f^{-1}(x) = 2 - \sqrt{x+3}$, **domain** $[-3, \infty)$ (the range of f).

Where does a function meet its inverse?

If f is **increasing**, every intersection of $y = f(x)$ and $y = f^{-1}(x)$ lies on $y = x$, so you can solve $f(x) = x$ instead. That's much easier.

Worked example 3 **The decreasing-function trap** 3 marks

Find all points of intersection of $f(x) = 1 - x^3$ and $y = f^{-1}(x)$.

Theory

An increasing function meets its inverse only on $y = x$. A decreasing function can also meet it at pairs of points swapped across $y = x$, where $f(a) = b$ and $f(b) = a$.

1 Solving $f(x) = x$: $1 - x^3 = x$, which has one real solution $x \approx 0.682$. That's one point, $(0.682, 0.682)$.

Using

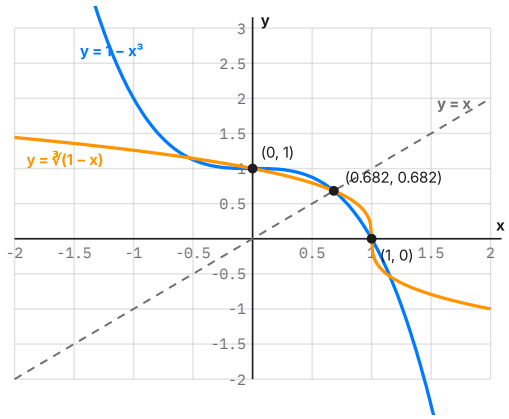
$f(x) = x$

2 But f is *decreasing*, so there can be intersections off the line $y = x$. Look for pairs with $f(a) = b$ and $f(b) = a$: $f(0) = 1$ and $f(1) = 0$.

Using

$f(a) = b$ and $f(b) = a$

✓ **Three points:** $(0, 1)$, $(1, 0)$ **and** $(0.682, 0.682)$ (to 3 d.p.). Here $f^{-1}(x) = \sqrt[3]{1-x}$, and a CAS solve of $f(x) = f^{-1}(x)$ confirms all three.



$y = 1 - x^3$ and its inverse $y = \sqrt[3]{1-x}$ meet at three points. Only one is on $y = x$.

Trick alert: composite and inverse traps

- $f^{-1}(x) \neq \frac{1}{f(x)}$. The inverse undoes f; the reciprocal is something else.
- **The domain of a composite comes from the inner function**, even if the simplified rule looks as if it's defined everywhere.
- **Check that the range fits inside the domain, value by value.** For $f(x) = \frac{1}{x-1}$ and $g(x) = x^2 + 1$, $\operatorname{ran} g = [1, \infty)$ includes 1, which isn't in $\operatorname{dom} f$. So $f \circ g$ doesn't exist on $\mathbb{R}$.
- **Choose the right branch** when you take a square root, using the range of the inverse.

Summary

- $f \circ g$ exists iff $\operatorname{ran} g \subseteq \operatorname{dom} f$; $\operatorname{dom}(f \circ g) = \operatorname{dom} g$.
- Inverse: one-to-one first; swap, solve, choose the branch; domain and range swap.
- Increasing f: solve $f(x) = x$ for intersections with f^{-1}. Decreasing f: check for points off $y = x$.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 20

30% correct

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Largest interval where both $f \circ g$ and $g \circ f$ exist (log and sine)

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 9) ↗

Answer: A · A 30% · B 19% · C 26% · D 14% · E 9%

$g \circ f$ needs $x > -\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}$. $f \circ g$ needs $\sin x > -\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}$, i.e. $x < \frac{5\pi}{4}$ here. Combined: $\left(-\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}, \frac{5\pi}{4}\right)$.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section B · Question 5

state average 35% of marks

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$g(x) = \frac{1}{2}f(2-x)$ with $f(x) = e^x + e^{-x}$: transformations, restricted inverses, areas with inverses, a family of curves

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 21) ↗

a. Complete the sequence of transformations from f to g (2 marks · state average 1.2 / 2, 60%)

- Reflection in the y-axis
- Then translation 2 units right (or just translate 2 right, since f is even)

Answer / notes: Dilation ½ from the x-axis, reflect in the y-axis, then translate right 2. Order matters.

b. Domain and range of the inverse of the increasing branch g_1 (2 marks · state average 1.0 / 2, 50%)

- Domain $[1, \infty)$
- Range $[2, \infty)$

Answer / notes: The domain and range of the inverse are swapped from g_1 (turning point (2, 1)).

c.i. Coordinates of P and Q (2 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.6 / 1, 60%)

- $P \approx (1.27, 1.27),\ Q \approx (4.09, 4.09)$

Answer / notes: Solve g(x) = x. Both points lie on y = x.

c.ii. Area bounded by g and the two inverses (2 d.p.) (2 marks · state average 0.6 / 2, 30%)

- $2\int_{1.27}^{4.09} (x - g(x))\,dx$
- ≈ 5.56

Answer / notes: Use the symmetry about y = x: double the area between y = x and g. Forgetting the 2 gives 2.78.

d. Integer n such that the turning point of h always lies on $y = 2x^n$ (1 mark · state average 0.1 / 1, 10%)

- $n = -1$

Answer / notes: The turning point is $\left(k, \frac{2}{k}\right)$, and $\frac{2}{k} = 2k^{-1}$.

e. Smallest k for which h meets the inverse of h_1 (2 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.0 / 1, 0%)

- $k \approx 1.27$

Answer / notes: Find the k where the curves just touch (a tangency condition). The state averaged 0.0/1.

f. Area between h and the inverse of h_1 when k = 5 (2 d.p.) (2 marks · state average 0.3 / 2, 15%)

- Intersections at x ≈ 1.45 and x ≈ 8.78
- Area ≈ 43.91

Answer / notes: Integrate $|h - h_1^{-1}|$ between the two intersection points.

Functional equations, odd & even functions

What's a functional equation?

A functional equation describes a *property* a function has for all inputs, such as $f(x+y)=f(x)f(y)$. VCAA usually asks "which function satisfies…" in multiple choice, or "show that f satisfies…" in short answer.

Property (for all x, y in the domain)	Satisfied by	Why
$f(x+y)=f(x)+f(y)$	$f(x)=kx$	$k(x+y)=kx+ky$
$f(x+y)=f(x)\,f(y)$	$f(x)=e^{kx}$ (or a^x)	index law $a^{x+y}=a^xa^y$
$f(xy)=f(x)+f(y)$	$f(x)=k\log_e x$	log law $\log(xy)=\log x+\log y$
$f(xy)=f(x)\,f(y)$	$f(x)=x^n$	$(xy)^n=x^ny^n$
$f(2x)=2f(x)$	$f(x)=kx$	$k(2x)=2(kx)$
$f(-x)=f(x)$	**even**: $x^2, \lvert x\rvert, \cos x, e^x+e^{-x}$	symmetric in the y-axis
$f(-x)=-f(x)$	**odd**: $x^3, \sin x, \tan x, \frac{1}{x}$	point symmetry about the origin
$f(f(x))=x$	self-inverse: $\frac{1}{x}, c-x$, some hyperbolas	graph symmetric in $y=x$

The number-test strategy

In multiple choice, don't do algebra first. Pick easy values ($x=1,\ y=2$, or $x=y=0$) and test each option. Usually three options fail on the first test. Then prove the survivor in your head.

Worked example 1 **Which function satisfies f(x + y) = f(x)f(y)?** 1 mark

Which one of $f(x)=3x$, $f(x)=x^3$, $f(x)=e^{3x}$, $f(x)=\log_e(3x)$ satisfies $f(x+y)=f(x)f(y)$ for all real x, y?

Theory

Testing simple values (like 0 and 1) quickly rules out functions that fail a functional equation. The exponential property $e^{a+b}=e^ae^b$ is what turns sums into products.

1. Test $x=y=0$: we need $f(0)=f(0)^2$, so $f(0)=0$ or 1. $\log_e(0)$ is undefined, so D is out.

   Using: test $x=y=0$

2. Test $x=y=1$: $3x$ gives 6 vs 9 ×; x^3 gives 8 vs 1 ×; e^{3x} gives e^6 vs $e^3\cdot e^3=e^6$ ✓.

   Using: test $x=y=1$

✓ $f(x)=e^{3x}$: $e^{3(x+y)}=e^{3x}e^{3y}$ for all x, y.

Using: $e^{a+b}=e^ae^b$

Worked example 2 **Finding a parameter** 2 marks

$f(x) = e^{kx}$ satisfies $f(x+1) = 2f(x)$ for all x. Find k.

Theory

Use index laws to split the exponential, then divide by the common factor (which is never zero) to isolate the parameter.

1 $e^{k(x+1)} = e^{kx}e^{k}$, so the condition is $e^{kx}e^{k} = 2e^{kx}$.

Using $e^{a+b} = e^{a}e^{b}$

Divide by e^{kx} (never 0): $e^{k} = 2$, so $k = \log_e 2$.

Using $e^{k} = 2 \iff k = \log_e 2$

Worked example 3 **Showing a symmetry property** 2 marks

Let $f(x) = x^2 - 2x$. Show that $f(1+h) = f(1-h)$ for all h, and interpret this.

Theory

$f(a+h) = f(a-h)$ for every h means points equally far either side of $x = a$ have the same height: the graph is symmetric about $x = a$.

1 $f(1+h) = (1+h)^2 - 2(1+h) = 1 + 2h + h^2 - 2 - 2h = h^2 - 1$.

Using expand $f(1+h)$

2 $f(1-h) = (1-h)^2 - 2(1-h) = 1 - 2h + h^2 - 2 + 2h = h^2 - 1$. Equal. ✓

Using expand $f(1-h)$

Points the same distance either side of $x = 1$ have the same height: **the graph is symmetric about the line** $x = 1$ (its axis of symmetry).

Worked example 4 **Linear functions with f(f(x)) = 4x + 3 (hard)** 3 marks

Find all linear functions $f(x) = ax + b$ such that $f(f(x)) = 4x + 3$ for all x.

Theory

If two polynomials are equal for all x, their corresponding coefficients must be equal. That gives equations for the unknowns.

1 $f(f(x)) = a(ax+b) + b = a^2x + ab + b$.

Using $f(f(x)) = a(ax+b) + b$

2 Equate coefficients: $a^2 = 4$ and $b(a+1) = 3$.

Using equate coefficients

$a = 2 \Rightarrow b = 1$; $a = -2 \Rightarrow -b = 3 \Rightarrow b = -3$. $f(x) = 2x + 1$ **or** $f(x) = -2x - 3$. Most students miss the second one.

Trick alert

- **"For all x" means one counter-example kills an option**, but one success doesn't prove it.
- **Watch the domain.** $f(x) = \log_e x$ satisfies $f(xy) = f(x) + f(y)$ only for $x, y > 0$.
- **Neither odd nor even is the usual case.** e^x, $x^2 + x$ and $\log_e x$ are neither.
- **A function can be odd and still have $f(0)$ undefined** (e.g. $\frac{1}{x}$). If an odd function is defined at 0, then $f(0) = 0$.

Summary

- Sums inside → products outside: exponential. Products inside → sums outside: log. Products → products: power.
- Even: $f(-x) = f(x)$. Odd: $f(-x) = -f(x)$.
- Multiple choice: test numbers first; $x = y = 0$ and $x = y = 1$ are your friends.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2025 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 9 — state average 27% of marks

© VCAA · full paper (p. 12) ↗

Solving $\frac{w^2}{(x-1)^2} = (x-w)^2$; the minimum of $(x-1)(x-w)$; when there are exactly three solutions

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 12) ↗

a. Four solutions when w = −3 (3 marks · state average 1.0 / 3, 33%)

- Reduces to $(x+3)(x-1) = \pm 3$
- $+3$: $x^2 + 2x - 6 = 0 \Rightarrow x = -1 \pm \sqrt{7}$
- -3: $x^2 + 2x = 0 \Rightarrow x = 0, -2$

Answer / notes: $x = -2, 0, -1 \pm \sqrt{7}$

b.i. Minimum point of $y = (x-1)(x-w)$, $w > 0$ (2 marks · state average 0.8 / 2, 40%)

- $x = \frac{w+1}{2}$
- $y = -\frac{(w-1)^2}{4}$

Answer / notes: $\left(\frac{w+1}{2}, -\frac{(w-1)^2}{4}\right)$

b.ii. Positive w giving exactly three solutions (2 marks · state average 0.1 / 2, 5%)

- $(x-1)(x-w) = w$ always gives 2 solutions, so $(x-1)(x-w) = -w$ must touch the minimum: $-w = -\frac{(w-1)^2}{4}$
- $w^2 - 6w + 1 = 0 \Rightarrow w = 3 \pm 2\sqrt{2}$

Answer / notes: $w = 3 \pm 2\sqrt{2}$. The state averaged 0.1/2.

Simultaneous equations & parameters

Two linear equations, two unknowns

Two lines in the plane either cross once (**unique solution**), are parallel (**no solution**) or are the same line (**infinitely many solutions**).

The parameter test

$$\begin{aligned} ax + by &= e \\ cx + dy &= f \end{aligned} \qquad \text{unique solution} \iff ad - bc \neq 0$$

If $ad - bc = 0$ the lines have the same gradient. Then check the constants: if one equation is a multiple of the other, there are infinitely many solutions; otherwise there are none.

Key idea

$ad - bc$ is the determinant of the coefficient matrix $\begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$. You don't need matrix theory. Just remember "unique ⇔ determinant ≠ 0", then test the special values by substituting them back in.

Worked example 1 **Classifying by a parameter** 4 marks

Consider $\begin{aligned} ax + 3y &= 3 \\ x + (a-2)y &= 1 \end{aligned}$. Find the values of a for which the system has (a) a unique solution, (b) no solution, (c) infinitely many solutions.

Theory

Two linear equations have a unique solution unless their lines are parallel (determinant zero). Then they're either the same line (infinitely many solutions) or distinct parallel lines (no solution).

1. Determinant: $a(a-2) - 3 \cdot 1 = a^2 - 2a - 3 = (a-3)(a+1)$. Zero when $a = 3$ or $a = -1$.

   Using $\det = a_1 b_2 - a_2 b_1 = 0$

2. $a = 3$: $3x + 3y = 3$ and $x + y = 1$. The first is 3 × the second, so they're the same line: infinitely many solutions.

   Using same line ⇒ infinitely many

3. $a = -1$: $-x + 3y = 3$ and $x - 3y = 1$, i.e. $x - 3y = -3$ and $x - 3y = 1$. Parallel, different lines: no solution.

   Using parallel, distinct ⇒ none

(a) $a \in \mathbb{R} \setminus \{-1, 3\}$; **(b)** $a = -1$; **(c)** $a = 3$.

Three equations, three unknowns

Use elimination to reduce to two equations in two unknowns, or use CAS in Exam 2 (solve the three equations together). Geometrically each equation is a plane; they may meet at a point, along a line (infinitely many solutions) or not at all.

Worked example 2 **A 3 × 3 system by elimination (tech-free)** 3 marks

Solve $x + y + z = 6, \quad 2x - y + z = 3, \quad x + 2y - z = 2.$

Theory

Eliminate one variable at a time by adding or subtracting equations, reducing a 3 × 3 system to 2 × 2 and then to one equation.

1 Add equations 1 and 3: $2x + 3y = 8$. Add equations 2 and 3: $3x + y = 5$.

Using

eliminate z

2 From $3x + y = 5$: $y = 5 - 3x$. Substitute: $2x + 15 - 9x = 8 \Rightarrow x = 1$, so $y = 2$.

Using

substitute

✓ Then $z = 6 - 1 - 2 = 3$. $(x, y, z) = (1, 2, 3)$. Check in equation 2: $2 - 2 + 3 = 3$. ✓

Worked example 3 **Infinitely many solutions in 3D (Exam 2 style)** 4 marks

For the system $x + y + z = 1, \quad x + 2y + 3z = 2, \quad x + 4y + kz = c$: (a) find k for which there is no unique solution; (b) for that k, find c so there are infinitely many solutions and give them in terms of a parameter.

Theory

Elimination reduces the system. If two reduced equations have identical left sides, the system has no unique solution: infinitely many if the right sides also agree, none if they don't.

1 (a) Subtract: (2) − (1) gives $y + 2z = 1$; (3) − (1) gives $3y + (k - 1)z = c - 1$.

Using

eliminate x

2 Triple the first: $3y + 6z = 3$. The two equations have the same left side when $k - 1 = 6$, i.e. $k = 7$.

Using

same left side ⇒ no unique solution

3 (b) With $k = 7$: infinitely many solutions need $c - 1 = 3$, so $c = 4$ (otherwise no solution). Let $z = t$: $y = 1 - 2t$, $x = 1 - y - z = t$.

Using

let $z = t$

✓ **(a)** $k = 7$. **(b)** $c = 4$; $(x, y, z) = (t,\ 1 - 2t,\ t),\ t \in \mathbb{R}$.

Lines meeting curves: the discriminant

Substitute the line into the curve to get a quadratic. Its discriminant $\Delta = b^2 - 4ac$ counts the intersections: $\Delta > 0$ two, $\Delta = 0$ one (the line is a **tangent**), $\Delta < 0$ none.

Worked example 4 **Tangent line condition** 3 marks

Find the values of m for which the line $y = mx + 1$ is a tangent to $y = x^2 + 2x + 2$.

Theory

A line meets a parabola where their equations are equal. A tangent touches at exactly one point, so the resulting quadratic has a discriminant of zero.

1 Equate: $x^2 + 2x + 2 = mx + 1 \Rightarrow x^2 + (2 - m)x + 1 = 0$.

Using

equate the two rules

2 Tangent $\Leftrightarrow \Delta = 0$: $(2 - m)^2 - 4 = 0 \Rightarrow 2 - m = \pm 2$.

Using

tangent $\iff \Delta = b^2 - 4ac = 0$

$m = 0$ **or** $m = 4$. (Check $m = 0$: the line $y = 1$ touches the parabola's vertex at $(-1, 1)$. ✓)

Literal equations

A literal equation has letters as well as the unknown: solve $ax + b = cx + d$ for x to get $x = \frac{d-b}{a-c}$, *provided* $a \neq c$. Always state the restriction: that's where the marks for "consider all cases" are.

Trick alert: parameter traps

- **Determinant = 0 doesn't tell you which case you're in.** Substitute each value back and test for "same line" vs "parallel".
- **Dividing by an expression containing a parameter** silently assumes it isn't 0. Handle that value separately.
- **"At least one solution"** means unique *or* infinitely many, so it includes the coincident case.
- **For x^2-coefficient parameters** (e.g. $kx^2 + 4x + 1 = 0$), check $k = 0$ separately: the equation becomes linear and has exactly one solution.

Summary

- Unique solution ⇔ determinant ≠ 0. At determinant = 0, substitute and compare constants.
- 3 × 3: eliminate to 2 × 2; a parameter family of solutions means planes share a line.
- Line and curve: substitute, then use the discriminant.
- Always handle "divide by zero" values of parameters separately.

Hardest real questions on this topic

Nothing on this topic made the hardest third of 2023–2025, so this is the hardest one there is.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 4 ★ 55% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 3) ↗

Values of k giving infinitely many solutions

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 3) ↗

Answer: B · A 15% · B 55% · C 10% · D 14% · E 4%

The determinant $k^2 + k - 20 = 0$ gives k = −5 or 4. Only k = −5 makes the equations identical. k = 4 gives parallel lines.

Newton's method, bisection & pseudocode

Newton's method

Start with a guess x_0 near a root. Draw the tangent at $(x_0, f(x_0))$; where it hits the x-axis is the next, usually better, estimate. Repeat.

Newton's method

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$$

Derivation: the tangent $y - f(x_n) = f'(x_n)(x - x_n)$ crosses $y = 0$ at $x = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$.

Worked example 1 **Two iterations by hand** 3 marks

Use Newton's method with $x_0 = 2$ to find x_2 for $f(x) = x^3 - 2x - 5$. Give x_2 correct to four decimal places.

Theory

Newton's method follows the tangent at the current estimate down to the x-axis. Each new estimate is where that tangent crosses, which is usually much closer to the root.

1 $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 2$. $f(2) = 8 - 4 - 5 = -1$, $f'(2) = 10$. So $x_1 = 2 - \frac{-1}{10} = 2.1$.

Using $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$

2 $f(2.1) = 9.261 - 4.2 - 5 = 0.061$, $f'(2.1) = 13.23 - 2 = 11.23$. So $x_2 = 2.1 - \frac{0.061}{11.23} = 2.09457\ldots$

Using $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$

✓ $x_2 \approx 2.0946$. (The true root is 2.094551...: two steps already give four correct decimal places.)

Worked example 2 **Estimating √2** 2 marks

Use Newton's method on $f(x) = x^2 - 2$ with $x_0 = 1$ to find x_1, x_2 and x_3.

Theory

Newton's method converges very quickly near a simple root: the number of correct digits roughly doubles each iteration.

1 $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{x_n^2 - 2}{2x_n}$. $x_1 = 1 - \frac{-1}{2} = 1.5$.

Using $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$

2 $x_2 = 1.5 - \frac{0.25}{3} = 1.41\overline{6}$; $x_3 = 1.41667 - \frac{0.0069444}{2.83333} \approx 1.414216$.

Using $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$

✓ $x_1 = 1.5,\ x_2 \approx 1.416667,\ x_3 \approx 1.414216$. The number of correct digits roughly doubles each step.

When Newton's method fails

Problem	What happens	Example
$f'(x_n) = 0$	Horizontal tangent never meets the axis: division by zero	$x^2 - 2$ with $x_0 = 0$
Near a stationary point	Tangent is nearly flat, so the next estimate shoots far away	$x^3 - 3x + 1$ with $x_0 = 1.01$
Cycling	Estimates bounce between values forever	$x^3 - 2x + 2$ with $x_0 = 0$: 0, 1, 0, 1, ...
Wrong root	Converges, but to a different root from the one you wanted	Starting on the far side of a turning point

Worked example 3 **Show that it cycles** 2 marks

Show that Newton's method applied to $f(x) = x^3 - 2x + 2$ with $x_0 = 0$ does not converge.

Theory

Newton's method can fail: if the tangents send the estimates back and forth, they cycle and never reach the root. A poor starting value or a stationary point nearby causes this.

1 $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 2$. $x_1 = 0 - \frac{2}{-2} = 1$.

Using $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$

2 $x_2 = 1 - \frac{1-2+2}{3-2} = 1 - 1 = 0$.

Using $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$

The estimates alternate 0, 1, 0, 1, ... and never approach the actual root (which is near $x \approx -1.77$).

The bisection method

If f is continuous and $f(a)$ and $f(b)$ have opposite signs, there's a root in $[a, b]$. Evaluate the midpoint $m = \frac{a+b}{2}$ and keep the half where the sign still changes. It's slow but reliable: after n steps the interval width is $\frac{b-a}{2^n}$.

Pseudocode, VCAA style

VCAA exams show algorithms in a simple pseudocode and ask you to trace them (fill in a table of values), find an output, or complete a missing line. The conventions: `←` means "assign", `define` creates a function, and loops are `for … end for` and `while … end while`.

```
define f(x)
    return x^3 - 2x - 5
define df(x)
    return 3x^2 - 2

x ← 2
for i from 1 to 3
    x ← x - f(x) / df(x)
end for
print x
```

This prints $x_3 \approx 2.094551$ (three iterations of Newton's method from $x_0 = 2$).

Worked example 4 **Trace a while loop** 3 marks

Trace this algorithm and state the output.

```
a ← 1
b ← 2
while b - a > 0.2
    m ← (a + b) / 2
    if m^2 - 2 < 0 then
        a ← m
    else
        b ← m
    end if
end while
print a, b
```

Theory

Bisection keeps an interval where the function changes sign, halving it each loop. The loop stops once the interval is narrower than the tolerance, so the root is trapped inside.

1. It's bisection on $x^2 - 2$. Start $a = 1, b = 2$ (width 1).
2. $m = 1.5$: $2.25 - 2 > 0$, so $b = 1.5$. $m = 1.25$: $1.5625 - 2 < 0$, so $a = 1.25$. Width now $0.25 > 0.2$: continue.

   Using $m = \frac{a+b}{2}$
3. $m = 1.375$: $1.890625 - 2 < 0$, so $a = 1.375$. Width $0.125 \leq 0.2$: stop.

   Using $m = \frac{a+b}{2}$

Output: 1.375, 1.5 (an interval containing $\sqrt{2} \approx 1.414$).

Trick alert: algorithm traps

- **Count loop iterations carefully.** `for i from 1 to 3` runs 3 times; a `while` loop checks its condition *before* each pass.
- **Use the updated value.** Once `x ← …` runs, every later line uses the new x.
- **Newton needs f', bisection needs a sign change.** Don't mix up the input requirements.
- **Keep full precision** in the calculator between iterations; round only the final answer.

Summary

- $x_{n+1} = x_n - \frac{f(x_n)}{f'(x_n)}$: fast, but it can fail near stationary points, cycle, or find a different root.
- Bisection: halve the interval while keeping a sign change. Slow but always works.
- Pseudocode: trace line by line, update variables immediately, and count loop passes carefully.

Hardest real questions on this topic

Nothing on this topic made the hardest third of 2023–2025, so this is the hardest one there is.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 13 ★ 52% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 6) ↗

Result of three Newton's method iterations on $x^3 + 3x - 3$ from $x_0 = 1$

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 6) ↗

Answer: C · A 16% · B 22% · C 52% · D 7% · E 3%

1 → 0.83333 → 0.81785 → 0.81773. Count exactly three iterations.

Limits, continuity & differentiability

Limits

$\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = L$ means $f(x)$ gets as close as we like to L as x gets close to a (from both sides). It doesn't matter what happens *at* $x = a$ itself.

Worked example 1 **Removing a 0/0 hole** — 1 mark

Evaluate $\lim_{x \to 3} \dfrac{x^2 - 9}{x - 3}$.

Theory

A limit asks what value the function approaches, not its value at the point. If substitution gives $\frac{0}{0}$, factorise and cancel the common factor, then substitute.

1 Direct substitution gives $\frac{0}{0}$: factorise. $\frac{(x-3)(x+3)}{x-3} = x + 3$ for $x \neq 3$.

Using: factorise and cancel

✓ $\lim = 3 + 3 = 6$. The graph is the line $y = x + 3$ with a hole at $(3, 6)$.

Limits at infinity: divide top and bottom by the highest power. $\lim_{x \to \infty} \dfrac{2x + 1}{x - 3} = \lim_{x \to \infty} \dfrac{2 + \frac{1}{x}}{1 - \frac{3}{x}} = 2$: the horizontal asymptote.

The derivative from first principles

Definition of the derivative

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(x + h) - f(x)}{h}$$

The fraction is the gradient of the **secant** through $(x, f(x))$ and $(x + h, f(x + h))$. As $h \to 0$, the secant becomes the **tangent**.

Worked example 2 **First principles (Exam 1 favourite)** — 3 marks

Use first principles to find the derivative of $f(x) = x^2 - 3x$.

Theory

The derivative is the limit of the gradient of a chord as its width h shrinks to zero. Expand, simplify, cancel h, and only then let $h \to 0$.

1 $f(x + h) = (x + h)^2 - 3(x + h) = x^2 + 2xh + h^2 - 3x - 3h$.

Using: $f(x + h)$

2 $f(x + h) - f(x) = 2xh + h^2 - 3h$, so $\dfrac{f(x + h) - f(x)}{h} = 2x + h - 3$ (for $h \neq 0$).

Using: $\dfrac{f(x + h) - f(x)}{h}$

✓ $f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0}(2x + h - 3) = 2x - 3$. Write "$\lim_{h \to 0}$" on every line until the last one: examiners deduct marks when it disappears too early.

Using: $f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0} \dfrac{f(x + h) - f(x)}{h}$

Continuity

f is continuous at $x = a$ if $f(a)$ is defined and $\lim_{x \to a} f(x) = f(a)$. In practice: you can draw through $x = a$ without lifting your pen. For a hybrid function, the left and right rules must give the same value at the join.

Differentiability

f is differentiable at $x = a$ if the left and right gradients exist and are equal. A function that is **not continuous** at a point is **not differentiable** there. But continuity alone isn't enough:

Feature	Continuous?	Differentiable?	Example
Jump or hole	No	No	Hybrid with mismatched pieces
Corner (sharp point)	Yes	No	$\lvert x \rvert$ at $x = 0$; $\lvert x^2 - 4 \rvert$ at $x = \pm 2$
Cusp	Yes	No	$x^{2/3}$ at $x = 0$
Vertical tangent	Yes	No	$x^{1/3}$ at $x = 0$
Endpoint of a closed domain	Yes	No (only one-sided)	$\sqrt{x}$ at $x = 0$

Exam tip

VCAA convention: a function is differentiable on an **open** interval. When asked for the domain of f', exclude endpoints and every corner, cusp, jump and vertical tangent.

Worked example 3 **A smooth join (continuous and differentiable)** 3 marks

Find a and b such that $f(x) = \begin{cases} ax^2 + b, & x \leq 1 \\ 4x - 1, & x > 1 \end{cases}$ is differentiable at $x = 1$.

Theory

A hybrid is differentiable at a join only if it's continuous there (the pieces meet) and the gradients from both sides are equal (a smooth join).

1 **Continuous:** $a(1)^2 + b = 4(1) - 1 \Rightarrow a + b = 3$.

Using

continuous: pieces meet

2 **Gradients match:** left derivative $2ax$ at $x = 1$ is $2a$; right derivative is 4. So $2a = 4$.

Using

differentiable: gradients match

$a = 2,\ b = 1$. Both conditions are needed. Matching gradients without continuity doesn't make the function differentiable.

Worked example 4 **Domain of the derivative** 2 marks

State the domain of f' for $f : [-3, 3] \to \mathbb{R},\ f(x) = |x^2 - 4|$.

Theory

A function isn't differentiable at a sharp corner (like where $|u|$ reflects the graph) or at the endpoints of a closed domain.

1 Corners where the graph is reflected: $x^2 - 4 = 0 \Rightarrow x = \pm 2$.
Endpoints ± 3 are also excluded.

Using

$|u|$ has a corner where $u = 0$

$(-3, -2) \cup (-2, 2) \cup (2, 3)$.

Trick alert: limit and differentiability traps

- **Continuous doesn't mean differentiable.** Every corner is continuous.
- **A limit can exist even where $f(a)$ doesn't** (a hole), and $f(a)$ can exist without the limit (a jump).
- **For hybrid gradients, differentiate each piece separately** and compare the values at the join. Don't differentiate across the join.
- **Endpoints:** derivatives are only defined on open intervals in VCAA's convention.

Summary

- $f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h}$: expand, cancel h, then let $h \to 0$.
- Continuous: no breaks. Differentiable: continuous *and* no corners, cusps or vertical tangents.
- Smooth hybrid join: match values *and* gradients.

Differentiation rules

The standard derivatives

$f(x)$	$f'(x)$	$f(x)$	$f'(x)$
x^n	nx^{n-1}	$\sin(kx)$	$k\cos(kx)$
$(ax+b)^n$	$an(ax+b)^{n-1}$	$\cos(kx)$	$-k\sin(kx)$
e^{kx}	ke^{kx}	$\tan(kx)$	$\dfrac{k}{\cos^2(kx)} = k\sec^2(kx)$
$\log_e(kx)$	$\dfrac{1}{x}$	$\log_e(g(x))$	$\dfrac{g'(x)}{g(x)}$

Rewrite roots and fractions as powers before differentiating: $\sqrt{x} = x^{1/2}$ and $\frac{3}{x^2} = 3x^{-2}$.

The three rules

Chain, product and quotient rules

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = \frac{dy}{du}\cdot\frac{du}{dx} \qquad (uv)' = u'v + uv' \qquad \left(\frac{u}{v}\right)' = \frac{u'v - uv'}{v^2}$$

Function notation for the chain rule: $\big(f(g(x))\big)' = f'(g(x))\cdot g'(x)$.

Key idea

Decide which rule to use from the **outermost** structure. x^2e^{3x} is a product. $e^{\sin x}$ is a composite (chain). $\frac{\sin x}{x}$ is a quotient. Many questions need two rules in a row.

Worked example 1 **Product rule, then factorise** 2 marks

Differentiate $y = x^2e^{3x}$ and fully factorise the result.

Theory

The product rule differentiates a product of two functions: derivative of the first times the second, plus the first times the derivative of the second. Factorising the result makes it easy to find where it's zero.

1 $u = x^2,\ u' = 2x;\ v = e^{3x},\ v' = 3e^{3x}$.

Using $u = x^2,\ v = e^{3x}$

$\dfrac{dy}{dx} = 2xe^{3x} + 3x^2e^{3x} = \boldsymbol{xe^{3x}(2+3x)}$. Factorised form makes stationary points easy: $x = 0$ or $x = -\frac{2}{3}$.

Using $\dfrac{d}{dx}(uv) = u'v + uv'$

Worked example 2 **Chain rule with a log** 2 marks

Find $\frac{dy}{dx}$ for (a) $y = \log_e(x^2 + 1)$, (b) $y = \log_e(\cos x)$.

Theory

The chain rule applied to a log gives a neat result: the derivative of $\log_e(g(x))$ is $g'(x)$ divided by $g(x)$.

1 Use $\frac{d}{dx}\log_e(g(x)) = \frac{g'(x)}{g(x)}$.

Using

$$\frac{d}{dx}\log_e(g(x)) = \frac{g'(x)}{g(x)}$$

(a) $\frac{2x}{x^2+1}$; **(b)** $\frac{-\sin x}{\cos x} = -\tan x$.

Worked example 3 **Quotient rule** 2 marks

Differentiate $f(x) = \frac{x}{x+1}$.

Theory

The quotient rule differentiates a fraction of two functions. Take care with the order in the numerator: $u'v$ comes first.

1 $u = x,\ u' = 1;\ v = x+1,\ v' = 1$.

Using

$u = x,\ v = x+1$

$f'(x) = \frac{1\cdot(x+1) - x\cdot 1}{(x+1)^2} = \boldsymbol{\frac{1}{(x+1)^2}}$, which is always positive, so f is increasing on each branch.

Using

$$\frac{d}{dx}\left(\frac{u}{v}\right) = \frac{u'v - uv'}{v^2}$$

Worked example 4 **Evaluate a derivative exactly (tech-free)** 2 marks

Let $f(x) = x^2\sin x$. Find $f'\left(\frac{\pi}{2}\right)$.

Theory

Differentiate with the product rule, then substitute the exact values of sin and cos at $\frac{\pi}{2}$.

1 $f'(x) = 2x\sin x + x^2\cos x$.

Using

$$\frac{d}{dx}(uv) = u'v + uv'$$

$f'\left(\frac{\pi}{2}\right) = 2\cdot\frac{\pi}{2}\cdot 1 + \frac{\pi^2}{4}\cdot 0 = \boldsymbol{\pi}$.

Using

$\sin\frac{\pi}{2} = 1,\ \cos\frac{\pi}{2} = 0$

Worked example 5 **Derivatives from a table (Exam 1 style)** 3 marks

The table gives values of f, g and their derivatives.

x	$f(x)$	$f'(x)$	$g(x)$	$g'(x)$
1	3	−2	2	5
2	4	7	1	−3

Exam 1 loves derivative tables: you never see the functions, only values. Apply the rule symbolically first, then read each value off the table, taking care which x each function is evaluated at.

Find the derivatives of (a) $f(g(x))$ at $x = 1$, (b) $f(x)g(x)$ at $x = 2$, (c) $[f(x)]^2$ at $x = 1$.

1 (a) $f'(g(1)) \cdot g'(1) = f'(2) \cdot 5 = 7 \times 5 = 35$.

Using $\frac{d}{dx} f(g(x)) = f'(g(x))\, g'(x)$

2 (b) $f'(2)g(2) + f(2)g'(2) = 7(1) + 4(-3) = -5$.

Using $\frac{d}{dx}(uv) = u'v + uv'$

3 (c) $2f(1)f'(1) = 2(3)(-2) = -12$.

Using $\frac{d}{dx}[f(x)]^2 = 2f(x)f'(x)$

(a) 35, (b) −5, (c) −12. In (a), f' is evaluated at $g(1) = 2$, not at 1. That's the trap.

Trick alert: differentiation traps

- $\frac{d}{dx}\log_e(2x) = \frac{1}{x}$, not $\frac{2}{x}$: the 2 cancels ($\frac{2}{2x}$).
- $\sin^2 x$ **vs** $\sin(x^2)$: $2\sin x \cos x$ vs $2x\cos(x^2)$.
- e^{x^2} **differentiates to** $2xe^{x^2}$, not $x^2e^{x^2-1}$. The power rule doesn't apply to exponentials.
- **The derivative of a constant is 0:** $\frac{d}{dx}e^2 = 0$ and $\frac{d}{dx}\pi^2 = 0$.
- **Quotient rule sign:** it's $u'v - uv'$ on top, so the order matters.

Summary

- Know the standard derivatives, including $\tan(kx) \to \frac{k}{\cos^2 kx}$ and $\log_e g \to \frac{g'}{g}$.
- Chain: derivative of outside (inside unchanged) × derivative of inside.
- Product: $u'v + uv'$. Quotient: $\frac{u'v - uv'}{v^2}$.
- Factorise derivatives: you'll usually need $f'(x) = 0$ next.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2025 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 16 18% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 9) ↗

Conditions on a, b if $h(x) = a\log_e(bx)$ has $h'(x) > 0$ everywhere

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 9) ↗

Answer: D · A 20% · B 16% · C 46% · D 18%

$h'(x) = \frac{a}{x}$, with domain $bx > 0$. If b > 0 then x > 0 and you need a > 0. If b < 0 then x < 0 and you need a < 0. Either way ab > 0.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 11 22% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 5) ↗

Gradient of f × g at x = −2 from given values

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 5) ↗

Answer: E · A 6% · B 13% · C 8% · D 51% · E 22%

Product rule: $3 \times 8 + (-7) \times 2 = 10$.

Applications of differentiation

Tangents and normals

Tangent and normal at $x = a$

$$\text{tangent: } y - f(a) = f'(a)(x - a) \qquad \text{normal: } y - f(a) = -\frac{1}{f'(a)}(x - a)$$

The normal is perpendicular to the tangent: $m_1 m_2 = -1$.

Worked example 1 **Tangent and normal** 3 marks

Find the equations of the tangent and the normal to $y = x^3 - 2x$ at $x = 1$.

Theory

The tangent touches the curve and has gradient $f'(a)$. The normal is perpendicular to the tangent, so its gradient is the negative reciprocal. Both pass through the point $(a, f(a))$.

1 Point: $y(1) = 1 - 2 = -1$, so $(1, -1)$. Gradient: $y' = 3x^2 - 2$, so $y'(1) = 1$.

Using

$m_{\text{tangent}} = f'(a)$

2 Tangent: $y + 1 = 1(x - 1) \Rightarrow y = x - 2$. Normal gradient $= -1$: $y + 1 = -(x - 1) \Rightarrow y = -x$.

Using

$y - y_1 = m(x - x_1)$

$m_{\text{normal}} = -\frac{1}{f'(a)}$

Tangent $y = x - 2$; normal $y = -x$.

Worked example 2 **Tangents through a point not on the curve (hard)** 4 marks

Find the equations of the tangents to $y = x^2$ that pass through the point $(1, -3)$.

Theory

If the given point isn't on the curve, you don't know where the tangent touches. Call the point of contact $(a, f(a))$, write the tangent in terms of a, then force it through the given point to solve for a.

1 Let the point of contact be (a, a^2). The gradient there is $2a$, so the tangent is $y - a^2 = 2a(x - a)$, i.e. $y = 2ax - a^2$.

Using

$y - f(a) = f'(a)(x - a)$

2 It must pass through $(1, -3)$: $-3 = 2a - a^2 \Rightarrow a^2 - 2a - 3 = 0 \Rightarrow (a - 3)(a + 1) = 0$.

Using

substitute the external point

$a = 3$: $y = 6x - 9$; $a = -1$: $y = -2x - 1$. The external point isn't on the curve, so you can't use it as the point of contact. Use a general point instead.

Worked example 3 **A common tangent to two curves (hard)** 4 marks

Find the equation of the straight line that is a tangent to both $y = x^2$ and $y = x^2 - 4x + 8$.

Theory
A line $y = mx + c$ is tangent to a parabola exactly when substituting it gives a quadratic with **one** solution, i.e. a discriminant of zero. A common tangent must do this for both curves, which gives two equations in m and c.

1. With $y = x^2$: $x^2 - mx - c = 0$, so $\Delta = m^2 + 4c = 0$, giving $c = -\frac{m^2}{4}$.

   Using
   $\Delta = b^2 - 4ac = 0 \Rightarrow$ one solution (tangent)

2. With $y = x^2 - 4x + 8$: $x^2 - (4 + m)x + (8 - c) = 0$, so $(4 + m)^2 - 4(8 - c) = 0$.

   Using
   $\Delta = b^2 - 4ac = 0$

3. Substitute $4c = -m^2$: $(4 + m)^2 - 32 - m^2 = 0 \Rightarrow 16 + 8m - 32 = 0 \Rightarrow m = 2$, so $c = -1$.

✓ $y = 2x - 1$. Check: it touches $y = x^2$ at $(1, 1)$ and $y = x^2 - 4x + 8$ at $(3, 5)$. If both curves have a turning point at the same height, that horizontal line is a common tangent too (gradient 0), so look for it first.

The angle a tangent makes with the x-axis

A line with gradient m makes an angle θ with the positive direction of the x-axis, where $\tan\theta = m$. A negative gradient gives an obtuse angle ($\theta = 180^\circ + \tan^{-1} m$, or $\pi + \tan^{-1} m$ in radians).

Rates of change

Average rate of change over $[a, b]$ = $\dfrac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}$ (gradient of a secant). **Instantaneous** rate at $x = a$ = $f'(a)$ (gradient of the tangent). Read the question carefully: VCAA asks for both, often in the same question.

Stationary points and their nature

Stationary points occur where $f'(x) = 0$. Classify with a **sign diagram of** f' or with the **second derivative**:

Sign of f' (left → right)	$f''(a)$	Nature
$+ \to -$	< 0	local maximum
$- \to +$	> 0	local minimum
$+ \to +$ or $- \to -$	$= 0$ (test fails!)	stationary point of inflection

⚠ **f''(a) = 0 doesn't prove an inflection**

$f(x) = x^4$ has $f'(0) = 0$ and $f''(0) = 0$, but $(0, 0)$ is a local *minimum*. When the second derivative is 0, go back to the sign test.

Worked example 4 **Full curve sketch of a cubic** 5 marks

For $f(x) = x^3 - 3x^2 - 9x + 5$, find the stationary points and their nature, the point of inflection, and the intervals where f is strictly decreasing.

Theory

Stationary points are where $f'(x) = 0$. The second derivative tells you the concavity there: concave down is a max, concave up is a min. A point of inflection is where the concavity changes, i.e. f'' changes sign.

1 $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 6x - 9 = 3(x - 3)(x + 1) = 0 \Rightarrow x = -1, 3.$

Using $f'(x) = 0$

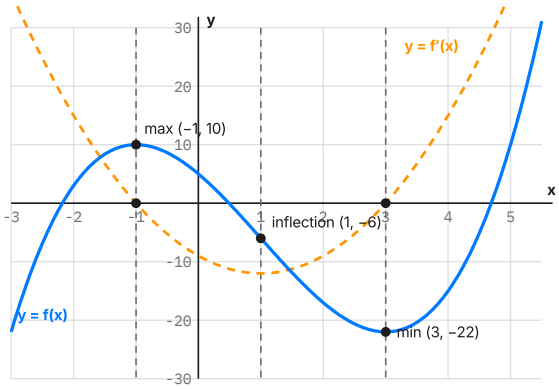
2 $f(-1) = -1 - 3 + 9 + 5 = 10$; $f(3) = 27 - 27 - 27 + 5 = -22$.
$f''(x) = 6x - 6$: $f''(-1) = -12 < 0$ (max), $f''(3) = 12 > 0$ (min).

Using $f''(a) < 0 \Rightarrow \max$, $f''(a) > 0 \Rightarrow \min$

3 Inflection: $f''(x) = 0 \Rightarrow x = 1$, and f'' changes sign there. $f(1) = -6$.

Using $f''(x) = 0$ and changes sign

Local max $(-1, 10)$, local min $(3, -22)$, inflection $(1, -6)$. Strictly decreasing on $[-1, 3]$. VCAA includes the endpoints of monotone intervals (the function is still strictly decreasing on the closed interval).



$f(x) = x^3 - 3x^2 - 9x + 5$ (solid) and its gradient function $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 6x - 9$ (dashed). Where f turns, f' crosses the axis; where f inflects, f' has its turning point.

"Hence verify there's a stationary point in the interval"

If f' is continuous on $[a, b]$ and $f'(a)$ and $f'(b)$ have **opposite signs**, then $f'(x) = 0$ somewhere in (a, b), so f has a stationary point there. It's the same sign-change idea as bisection, applied to f'. "Verify" means evaluate and conclude; don't solve $f'(x) = 0$ exactly.

Concavity and points of inflection

$f''(x) > 0$: concave up (gradient increasing). $f''(x) < 0$: concave down. A **point of inflection** is where the concavity changes; it may or may not be stationary. At a non-stationary inflection point the gradient is at a local max or min, so it's where a quantity grows fastest or slowest (a favourite Exam 2 context).

Worked example 5 **Max and inflection of x e^(−x)** 4 marks

For $f(x) = xe^{-x}$, find the coordinates of the stationary point and the point of inflection.

Theory

Same routine as any curve sketch, but the product rule is needed at each stage. Factorising out e^{-x} makes the equations easy to solve, because e^{-x} is never zero.

1 $f'(x) = e^{-x} - xe^{-x} = (1-x)e^{-x} = 0 \Rightarrow x = 1$. $f(1) = e^{-1}$; f' goes $+ \to -$, so it's a maximum.

Using
$\frac{d}{dx}(uv) = u'v + uv'$
$e^{-x} \neq 0$

2 $f''(x) = -e^{-x} - (1-x)e^{-x} = (x-2)e^{-x} = 0 \Rightarrow x = 2$, and it changes sign.

Using
$f''(x) = 0$ and changes sign

✓ **Local max $\left(1, \frac{1}{e}\right)$; inflection $\left(2, \frac{2}{e^2}\right)$.**

Sketching the gradient function

- Stationary points of f → x-intercepts of f'.
- f increasing → f' above the axis; f decreasing → f' below.
- Inflection points of f → turning points of f'.
- Corners/cusps of f → open circles or gaps in f'. Vertical asymptotes stay as asymptotes.

Trick alert: curve-sketching traps

- **Stationary point ≠ turning point.** Turning points are only the maxima and minima; stationary inflections also have $f' = 0$.
- **Local ≠ absolute.** The absolute maximum on a closed interval might be at an endpoint.
- **Normal gradient:** negative reciprocal. If the tangent is horizontal, the normal is vertical ($x = a$).
- **A factor squared in f'** (e.g. $f'(x) = (x-2)^2(x+1)$) gives no sign change at $x = 2$: stationary inflection.

Summary

- Tangent: $y - f(a) = f'(a)(x-a)$. For tangents through an external point, use a general contact point $(a, f(a))$.
- Stationary points: solve $f' = 0$; classify with a sign diagram (safest) or f''.
- Inflection: f'' changes sign; the gradient is at its greatest or least there.
- Monotone intervals are given as closed intervals in VCAA solutions.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 14 29% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 7) ↗

Number of tangents to a cubic that pass through its positive x-intercept
Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 7) ↗

Answer: D · A 6% · B 33% · C 22% · D 29% · E 10%

Set up the tangent at a general point and require it to pass through $\left(\frac{1}{3}, 0\right)$. The resulting cubic in the tangent point has 3 real solutions.

2024 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 8

state average 34% of marks

© VCAA · full paper (p. 10) ↗

Cube-root function $g(x) = \sqrt[3]{x-k} + m$: y-intercept, gradient there, through the origin, a second point with equal gradient

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 10) ↗

a. Coordinates of the y-intercept P (1 mark · state average 0.6 / 1, 60%)

- $\left(0,\ m - \sqrt[3]{k}\right)$

Answer / notes: $P = \left(0, m - \sqrt[3]{k}\right)$ (the cube root of −k is $-\sqrt[3]{k}$).

b. Gradient of g at P in terms of k (2 marks · state average 0.8 / 2, 40%)

- $g'(x) = \frac{1}{3}(x-k)^{-2/3}$
- $g'(0) = \frac{1}{3k^{2/3}}$

Answer / notes: $\frac{1}{3\sqrt[3]{k^2}}$. Keep it positive: $(-k)^{2/3} = k^{2/3}$.

c. k in terms of m if the graph passes through the origin (1 mark · state average 0.5 / 1, 50%)

- $k = m^3$

Answer / notes: $m - \sqrt[3]{k} = 0 \Rightarrow k = m^3$

d. Coordinates of Q (≠ P) with the same gradient, graph through the origin (3 marks · state average 0.5 / 3, 17%)

- $(x-k)^{2/3} = k^{2/3} \Rightarrow x - k = \pm k$
- $x = 2k$ (x = 0 is P)
- $Q = (2m^3, 2m)$

Answer / notes: By the symmetry of the cube root about its inflection point (k, m): $Q = (2m^3, 2m)$. The state averaged 0.5/3.

Optimisation (max/min problems)

The method

1. **Draw a diagram** and label the variable(s).
2. **Write the quantity to optimise** as a function of *one* variable (use the constraint to eliminate the others).
3. **State the domain** (lengths positive, can't cut more than you have...).
4. **Differentiate and solve** $= 0$; check the nature.
5. **Check the endpoints** and answer the question actually asked (the maximum volume? the dimensions? the time?).

Exam tip

VCAA marking schemes award a mark for a correct expression in one variable and often for the domain, before any calculus. Show them.

Worked example 1 **The open box** — 4 marks

Squares of side x cm are cut from each corner of a 24 cm × 24 cm sheet, and the sides are folded up to make an open box. Find the maximum volume.

Theory

Optimisation always goes: write the quantity as a function of one variable, state the domain, set the derivative to zero, then justify it's a max or min (sign test or second derivative) and check the endpoints.

1. $V = x(24 - 2x)^2$, domain $0 < x < 12$.

   Using $V = lwh$

2. $V'(x) = (24 - 2x)^2 + x \cdot 2(24 - 2x)(-2) = (24 - 2x)(24 - 6x)$.

   Using $\frac{d}{dx}(uv) = u'v + uv'$ and $\frac{d}{dx} f(g(x)) = f'(g(x))\, g'(x)$

3. $V' = 0 \Rightarrow x = 12$ (outside the domain; zero volume) or $x = 4$. Sign: $V' > 0$ before 4, < 0 after, so it's a maximum.

   Using $V'(x) = 0$

✓ $V_{\max} = 4(16)^2 = 1024 \text{ cm}^3$ when $x = 4$.

Worked example 2 **Fence against a wall** 3 marks

A farmer has 60 m of fencing to enclose a rectangular pen against a long straight wall (the wall forms one side). Find the maximum area.

Theory

The fixed amount of fencing is the constraint: use it to write one side in terms of the other, so the area depends on only one variable.

1 Let the two sides perpendicular to the wall be w. The side parallel to the wall is $60 - 2w$. $A = w(60 - 2w)$, $0 < w < 30$.

Using
$A = lw$

2 $A'(w) = 60 - 4w = 0 \Rightarrow w = 15$. $A'' = -4 < 0$: maximum.

Using
$A'(w) = 0$
$A'' < 0 \Rightarrow \max$

✓ $A_{\max} = 15 \times 30 = 450\ \text{m}^2$.

Worked example 3 **Minimum surface area of a can** 4 marks

A closed cylindrical can must hold 500 cm³. Find the radius that minimises its surface area, correct to two decimal places, and the minimum area.

Theory

There are two variables (r and h) but a fixed volume links them. Use the volume constraint to eliminate h, then minimise the surface area as a function of r alone.

1 Constraint: $\pi r^2 h = 500 \Rightarrow h = \dfrac{500}{\pi r^2}$.

Using
$V = \pi r^2 h$

2 $S = 2\pi r^2 + 2\pi r h = 2\pi r^2 + \dfrac{1000}{r}$, $r > 0$.

Using
$S = 2\pi r^2 + 2\pi r h$

3 $S'(r) = 4\pi r - \dfrac{1000}{r^2} = 0 \Rightarrow r^3 = \dfrac{250}{\pi}$.

Using
$S'(r) = 0$

✓ $r = \left(\frac{250}{\pi}\right)^{1/3} \approx 4.30$ **cm**, giving $S_{\min} \approx 348.73\ \text{cm}^2$. (At the optimum $h = 2r$: the height equals the diameter.)

Worked example 4 **Closest point on a curve** 4 marks

Find the minimum distance from the point $(0, 3)$ to the parabola $y = x^2$.

Theory

Distance involves a square root, which is messy to differentiate. Because the square root is increasing, the x that minimises d^2 also minimises d, so minimise $D = d^2$ instead.

1 A point on the curve is (x, x^2). Minimise the *square* of the distance (easier, same minimising x): $D = x^2 + (x^2 - 3)^2$.

Using $d^2 = (x_2 - x_1)^2 + (y_2 - y_1)^2$

2 $D'(x) = 2x + 4x(x^2 - 3) = 2x(2x^2 - 5) = 0 \Rightarrow x = 0$ or $x^2 = \frac{5}{2}$.

Using $D'(x) = 0$

3 $D(0) = 9$ (local max of D); D at $x^2 = \frac{5}{2}$: $\frac{5}{2} + \frac{1}{4} = \frac{11}{4}$.

Minimum distance $= \sqrt{\frac{11}{4}} = \frac{\sqrt{11}}{2}$, at $\left(\pm\sqrt{\frac{5}{2}}, \frac{5}{2}\right)$.

Worked example 5 **Swim then run (Exam 2 style)** 4 marks

A swimmer is 3 km offshore, directly opposite point P on a straight beach. She wants to reach a café on the beach 8 km from P. She swims at 2 km/h and runs at 5 km/h. Where should she land to minimise the total time?

Theory

Total time is the sum of each leg's distance divided by its speed. The swim leg is a hypotenuse, so it needs Pythagoras. Because the domain is closed, the endpoints must also be checked.

1 Land x km from P towards the café. $T(x) = \frac{\sqrt{9 + x^2}}{2} + \frac{8 - x}{5}$, $0 \le x \le 8$.

Using $t = \frac{\text{distance}}{\text{speed}}$
$d = \sqrt{a^2 + b^2}$

2 $T'(x) = \frac{x}{2\sqrt{9 + x^2}} - \frac{1}{5} = 0 \Rightarrow 5x = 2\sqrt{9 + x^2} \Rightarrow 21x^2 = 36$.

Using $T'(x) = 0$

3 $x = \frac{6}{\sqrt{21}} \approx 1.31$ km, giving $T \approx 2.975$ h. Endpoints: $T(0) = 3.1$ h, $T(8) \approx 4.27$ h.

Using compare with the endpoints

Land about 1.31 km from P; the minimum time is about 2.97 h (2 h 58.5 min).

Endpoints: absolute max and min

On a closed interval, the absolute maximum and minimum are among the stationary points **and the endpoints**. Evaluate all of them and compare.

Worked example 6 **Absolute extrema on [−2, 3]** 3 marks

Find the absolute maximum and minimum of $f(x) = x^3 - 3x$ on $[-2, 3]$.

Theory

On a closed interval, the absolute max and min happen either at a stationary point or at an endpoint. Evaluate the function at all of them and pick the largest and smallest.

1 $f'(x) = 3x^2 - 3 = 0 \Rightarrow x = \pm 1$. $f(-1) = 2$, $f(1) = -2$.

Using $f'(x) = 0$

2 Endpoints: $f(-2) = -8 + 6 = -2$, $f(3) = 27 - 9 = 18$.

Using evaluate the endpoints

Absolute max 18 (at $x = 3$); absolute min -2 (at $x = -2$ and $x = 1$). The local max of 2 isn't the absolute max.

Trick alert: optimisation traps

- **Forgetting the endpoints.** Especially when a stationary point is outside the domain.
- **Answering the wrong question.** "Find the maximum area" wants the area, not x.
- **Two variables left in the function.** Use the constraint to eliminate one before differentiating.
- **Rounding too early.** Keep the exact x (or full calculator value) until the final answer.

Summary

- One-variable function + domain → derivative = 0 → check nature → check endpoints.
- Distance problems: minimise the distance squared.
- Give the quantity asked for, with units, to the precision asked for.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2025 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 19 14% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 12) ↗

Value of c when the shortest distance from $y = x + c$ to $y = \log_e(x - 1)$ is $\sqrt{2}$

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 12) ↗

Answer: D · A 35% · B 25% · C 24% · D 14%

The closest point on the curve has gradient 1: (2, 0). Distance $\frac{|2+c|}{\sqrt{2}} = \sqrt{2}$ gives c = 0 or −4, but c = −4 cuts the curve (distance 0), so c = 0.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 17 28% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 8) ↗

Volume of a cylinder cut from a sheet, in terms of x and y

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 8) ↗

Answer: B · A 6% · B 28% · C 26% · D 26% · E 13%

The circumference $y = 2\pi r$ and $h = x - 4r$, so $V = \pi r^2 h = \frac{\pi x y^2 - 2y^3}{4\pi^2}$.

Antidifferentiation

Standard antiderivatives

Antidifferentiation reverses differentiation: if $F'(x) = f(x)$ then $\int f(x)\,dx = F(x) + c$.

$f(x)$	$\int f(x)\,dx$	$f(x)$	$\int f(x)\,dx$
$x^n,\ n \neq -1$	$\dfrac{x^{n+1}}{n+1} + c$	e^{kx}	$\dfrac{1}{k}e^{kx} + c$
$(ax+b)^n,\ n \neq -1$	$\dfrac{(ax+b)^{n+1}}{a(n+1)} + c$	$\sin(kx)$	$-\dfrac{1}{k}\cos(kx) + c$
$\dfrac{1}{x}$	$\log_e \lvert x \rvert + c$	$\cos(kx)$	$\dfrac{1}{k}\sin(kx) + c$
$\dfrac{1}{ax+b}$	$\dfrac{1}{a}\log_e \lvert ax+b \rvert + c$	$\dfrac{1}{\cos^2(kx)}$	$\dfrac{1}{k}\tan(kx) + c$

Key idea

Linear inside, divide by the coefficient of x. That's the reverse chain rule, and it only works when the inside is linear. $\int e^{x^2}\,dx$ is *not* $\frac{e^{x^2}}{2x}$.

Worked example 1 **A mixed antiderivative** 2 marks

Find $\displaystyle\int \left(6x^2 - \frac{4}{x^3} + \frac{2}{2x+1} + e^{-3x}\right) dx$.

Theory

Antidifferentiate term by term. Rewrite powers of x in the denominator as negative powers first. Linear inside functions ($ax+b$ or kx) divide by the coefficient of x.

1 Term by term: $2x^3$; $-4 \cdot \frac{x^{-2}}{-2} = \frac{2}{x^2}$; $\frac{2}{2}\log_e \lvert 2x+1 \rvert = \log_e \lvert 2x+1 \rvert$; $-\frac{1}{3}e^{-3x}$.

Using

$$\int x^n\,dx = \frac{x^{n+1}}{n+1} + c$$

$$\int \frac{1}{ax+b}\,dx = \frac{1}{a}\log_e \lvert ax+b \rvert + c$$

$$\int e^{kx}\,dx = \frac{1}{k}e^{kx} + c$$

$2x^3 + \dfrac{2}{x^2} + \log_e \lvert 2x+1 \rvert - \dfrac{1}{3}e^{-3x} + c.$

Worked example 2 **Function from derivative and a point** 2 marks

$f'(x) = 3x^2 - 4x + 1$ and $f(1) = 2$. Find $f(x)$.

Theory

Antidifferentiating gives a whole family of curves (the $+c$). A known point on the curve picks out the one you want.

1 $f(x) = x^3 - 2x^2 + x + c.$

Using

$$\int x^n \, dx = \frac{x^{n+1}}{n+1} + c$$

✓ $f(1) = 1 - 2 + 1 + c = 2 \Rightarrow c = 2.$ $f(x) = x^3 - 2x^2 + x + 2.$

Using

substitute the point to find c

Worked example 3 **Trig with a boundary condition** 3 marks

The gradient of a curve is $\frac{dy}{dx} = 2\cos(2x) + \sin x$, and the curve passes through $\left(\frac{\pi}{2}, 3\right)$. Find y.

Theory

Antidifferentiate each trig term, then use the given point to find c. Remember that $\sin$ goes to $-\cos$, and that the inside coefficient divides.

1 $y = \sin(2x) - \cos x + c.$

Using

$$\int \cos(kx) \, dx = \frac{1}{k}\sin(kx) + c$$

$$\int \sin x \, dx = -\cos x + c$$

2 $3 = \sin \pi - \cos \frac{\pi}{2} + c = 0 - 0 + c.$

Using

substitute the point to find c

✓ $y = \sin(2x) - \cos x + 3.$

Antidifferentiation by recognition

This is an Exam 1 staple: "Differentiate $g(x)$. Hence find an antiderivative of $h(x)$." Differentiate, rearrange so the thing you want is on its own, then antidifferentiate both sides.

Worked example 4 **Hence find ∫ log x dx** 3 marks

Find $\frac{d}{dx}(x \log_e x)$. Hence find $\int \log_e x \, dx$.

Theory

"Hence" questions use antidifferentiation by recognition: if you know $\frac{d}{dx}F(x) = f(x) + g(x)$, then integrating both sides gives $F(x) = \int f + \int g$. Rearrange for the integral you want.

1. Product rule: $\frac{d}{dx}(x \log_e x) = \log_e x + x \cdot \frac{1}{x} = \log_e x + 1$.

   Using $\frac{d}{dx}(uv) = u'v + uv'$

2. Antidifferentiate both sides: $x \log_e x = \int \log_e x \, dx + \int 1 \, dx$.

   Using $\int \frac{d}{dx}F(x) \, dx = F(x) + c$

✓ $\int \log_e x \, dx = x \log_e x - x + c$.

Worked example 5 **Hence find ∫ x cos x dx** 3 marks

Differentiate $x \sin x$ and hence find an antiderivative of $x \cos x$.

Theory

Differentiate the given function, rearrange so the integrand is on its own, then integrate both sides. The derivative term integrates straight back to the original function.

1. $\frac{d}{dx}(x \sin x) = \sin x + x \cos x$, so $x \cos x = \frac{d}{dx}(x \sin x) - \sin x$.

   Using $\frac{d}{dx}(uv) = u'v + uv'$

✓ $\int x \cos x \, dx = x \sin x - \int \sin x \, dx = \boldsymbol{x \sin x + \cos x}$ (plus c if they ask for the general antiderivative).

Using $\int \frac{d}{dx}F(x) \, dx = F(x)$ and $\int \sin x \, dx = -\cos x$

Graphs of antiderivatives

If you're given the graph of f and asked to sketch F (where $F' = f$): where f is positive, F increases; where f crosses the axis, F has a stationary point; turning points of f are inflection points of F. There's a whole family of possible F graphs, each a vertical translation of the others.

Trick alert: antiderivative traps

- $\int \frac{1}{x} \, dx \neq \frac{x^0}{0}$. The power rule excludes $n = -1$; use $\log_e |x|$.
- **Sign flip for sine:** $\int \sin x \, dx = -\cos x + c$.
- $\int \frac{1}{3x} \, dx = \frac{1}{3} \log_e |x| + c$, which equals $\frac{1}{3} \log_e |3x| + c'$: both are correct (the constants differ).
- **Don't forget** $+c$ when a question asks for "the general antiderivative" or "$\int \ldots dx$". When it asks for "an antiderivative", $c = 0$ is fine.

Summary

- Reverse each derivative rule; with a linear inside, divide by its coefficient.
- $\int \frac{1}{x}\,dx = \log_e|x| + c$; $\int \sin x\,dx = -\cos x + c$.
- Use a known point to find c.
- “Hence” questions: differentiate, rearrange, antidifferentiate.

Hardest real questions on this topic

Nothing on this topic made the hardest third of 2023–2025, so this is the hardest one there is.

2025 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 2 ★

state average 60% of marks

© VCAA · full paper (p. 3) ↗

Find $g(x)$ given $g'(x) = \frac{1}{2x+3}$ and $g(1) = 0$

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 3) ↗

Antidifferentiate and use the condition (2 marks · state average 1.2 / 2, 60%)

- $g(x) = \frac{1}{2}\log_e(2x+3) + c$
- $c = -\frac{1}{2}\log_e 5$, so $g(x) = \frac{1}{2}\log_e\left(\frac{2x+3}{5}\right)$

Answer / notes: $g(x) = \frac{1}{2}\log_e(2x+3) - \frac{1}{2}\log_e 5$. Don’t forget the $\frac{1}{2}$ from the chain rule.

Definite integrals, areas & average value

The fundamental theorem

Fundamental theorem of calculus

$$\int_a^b f(x)\,dx = F(b) - F(a) \quad \text{where } F' = f \qquad \frac{d}{dx}\int_a^x f(t)\,dt = f(x)$$

The definite integral gives the **signed area** between the graph and the x-axis: area above counts positive, area below counts negative.

Properties

$$\int_a^a f = 0 \qquad \int_b^a f = -\int_a^b f \qquad \int_a^b f + \int_b^c f = \int_a^c f \qquad \int_a^b (kf + g) = k\int_a^b f + \int_a^b g$$

Constants integrate to (constant) × (interval width): $\int_a^b k\,dx = k(b-a)$.

Worked example 1 **Using properties (Exam 1 classic)** 2 marks

Given $\int_1^4 f(x)\,dx = 5$, find $\int_1^4 \big(2f(x)+1\big)\,dx$ and $\int_4^1 f(x)\,dx$.

Theory

Definite integrals are linear: constants factor out and sums split. A constant k integrated over $[a,b]$ gives $k(b-a)$, not k. Swapping the limits changes the sign.

1 $2\int_1^4 f + \int_1^4 1\,dx = 2(5) + (4-1) = 13$.

Using
$\int_a^b (kf+g) = k\int_a^b f + \int_a^b g$
$\int_a^b 1\,dx = b-a$

✓ **13 and -5.** The common error is $2(5)+1 = 11$: the 1 must be integrated over an interval of width 3.

Using
$\int_b^a f = -\int_a^b f$

Signed area vs actual area

Worked example 2 **When part of the region is below the axis** 3 marks

For $f(x) = x^2 - 1$ on $[0,2]$, find (a) $\int_0^2 f(x)\,dx$ and (b) the total area between the graph and the x-axis.

Theory

The definite integral gives signed area: area below the axis counts as negative. For total area, split at each x-intercept and take the absolute value of each piece.

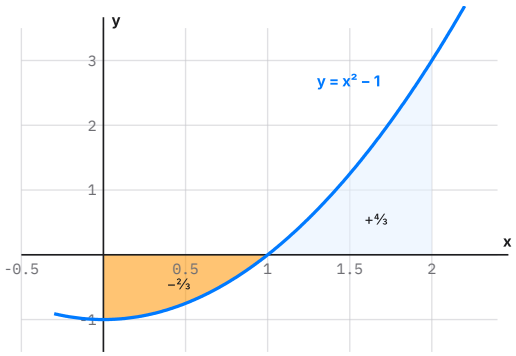
1 (a) $\left[\frac{x^3}{3} - x\right]_0^2 = \frac{8}{3} - 2 = \frac{2}{3}$.

Using
$\int_a^b f(x)\,dx = F(b) - F(a)$

2 (b) The graph crosses at $x = 1$. Area $= -\int_0^1 (x^2-1)\,dx + \int_1^2 (x^2-1)\,dx = \frac{2}{3} + \frac{4}{3}$.

Using
$\text{area} = \left|\int_a^c f\right| + \left|\int_c^b f\right|$

✓ **(a) $\frac{2}{3}$ (signed); (b) 2 square units.** Always sketch first and split at the x-intercepts.



$y = x^2 - 1$ on $[0, 2]$: the region below the axis has area $\frac{2}{3}$ and the region above has area $\frac{4}{3}$. The integral subtracts them ($\frac{4}{3} - \frac{2}{3} = \frac{2}{3}$); the area adds them (2).

Area between curves

Area between curves

$$A = \int_a^b (\text{upper} - \text{lower})\, dx$$

Find the intersection points first. If the curves swap over, split the integral where they cross. Upper − lower works whether the region is above or below the axis.

Worked example 3 **Area enclosed by y = x and y = x²** 2 marks

Find the area of the region enclosed by $y = x$ and $y = x^2$.

Theory

The area between two curves is the integral of (upper minus lower) between their intersection points. Find the intersections first, then check which curve is on top.

1 Intersections: $x = x^2 \Rightarrow x = 0, 1$. On $(0, 1)$, $x > x^2$.

Using

solve $f(x) = g(x)$

$A = \int_0^1 (x - x^2)\, dx = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{3} = \mathbf{\frac{1}{6}}$ square units.

Using

$A = \int_a^b (\text{upper} - \text{lower})\, dx$

Worked example 4 **Between sin and cos (tech-free)** 3 marks

Find the area enclosed between $y = \sin x$ and $y = \cos x$ from $x = \frac{\pi}{4}$ to $x = \frac{5\pi}{4}$.

Theory
Same area-between-curves method. Here the limits are the intersection points, and the exact values of $\sin$ and $\cos$ at $\frac{\pi}{4}$ and $\frac{5\pi}{4}$ do the rest.

1 They meet at $\frac{\pi}{4}$ and $\frac{5\pi}{4}$ (where $\tan x = 1$); in between, $\sin x \geq \cos x$.

Using
$\tan x = 1$ at intersections

2 $\int_{\pi/4}^{5\pi/4} (\sin x - \cos x)\, dx = \left[-\cos x - \sin x \right]_{\pi/4}^{5\pi/4} = \left(\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2} + \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2} \right) - \left(-\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2} - \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2} \right)$.

Using
$A = \int_a^b (\text{upper} - \text{lower})\, dx$
$\int \sin x\, dx = -\cos x$
$\int \cos x\, dx = \sin x$

✓ **$2\sqrt{2}$ square units.**

Worked example 5 **A symmetric region (CAS)** 3 marks

Find the total area enclosed between $y = x^3 - x$ and $y = 3x$.

Theory
When curves cross more than once, the upper curve switches. Split the integral at each intersection, or the positive and negative parts cancel. Symmetry can halve the work.

1 Intersections: $x^3 - x = 3x \Rightarrow x(x^2 - 4) = 0 \Rightarrow x = -2, 0, 2$.

Using
solve $f(x) = g(x)$

2 On $(0, 2)$, $3x$ is on top; on $(-2, 0)$, the cubic is on top. By symmetry (both are odd functions), the two regions are equal.

Using
odd functions: $f(-x) = -f(x)$

✓ $A = 2\int_0^2 \left(3x - (x^3 - x)\right) dx = 2\left[2x^2 - \frac{x^4}{4}\right]_0^2 = 2(8 - 4) = \mathbf{8}$.
$\int_{-2}^{2} (3x - x^3 + x)\, dx = 0$: don't integrate straight across a crossing.

Using
$A = \int_a^b (\text{upper} - \text{lower})\, dx$

Average value

Average value of f on $[a, b]$

$$f_{\text{avg}} = \frac{1}{b - a} \int_a^b f(x)\, dx$$

The height of the rectangle on $[a, b]$ with the same (signed) area as the region under f.

Worked example 6 **Average value of e^x** 2 marks

Find the average value of $f(x) = e^x$ on $[0, 2]$.

Theory

The average value of a function is the constant height that gives the same area over the interval: total area divided by the width.

1 $\frac{1}{2}\int_0^2 e^x\,dx = \frac{1}{2}\left[e^x\right]_0^2$.

Using

average value $= \frac{1}{b-a}\int_a^b f(x)\,dx$

$\frac{e^2-1}{2} \approx 3.19$. This is not the same as the average of $f(0)$ and $f(2)$ (≈ 4.19).

From rates to totals

If $R(t)$ is a rate (litres/min, cars/hour, m/s), then $\int_a^b R(t)\,dt$ is the **net change** in the quantity from $t = a$ to $t = b$.

Trick alert: integration traps

- **"Area" is never negative.** Split at the x-intercepts and add magnitudes.
- **Constant terms integrate to (constant) × width**, not the constant itself.
- **Upper – lower**, not "curve – axis", for regions between curves.
- **Average value divides by $b - a$**, not by 2.
- **Exact vs approximate:** an Exam 1 area like $\frac{e^2-1}{2}$ must stay exact.

Summary

- $\int_a^b f = F(b) - F(a)$ gives signed area; split at the x-intercepts for actual area.
- Between curves: $\int(\text{upper} - \text{lower})$, split where they cross.
- Average value: $\frac{1}{b-a}\int_a^b f$.
- $\frac{d}{dx}\int_a^x f(t)\,dt = f(x)$.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2025 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 17 38% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 10) ↗

Which graph fits $\int_1^2 f\,dx > \int_1^3 f\,dx$

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 10) ↗

Answer: A · A 38% · B 20% · C 17% · D 24%

The condition means $\int_2^3 f(x)\,dx < 0$, so f must be mostly below the axis on [2, 3].

2024 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 20 41% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 10) ↗

$\int_2^6 f(x)\,dx$ for a period-2 function with average value k on [0, 2]

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 10) ↗

Answer: C · A 20% · B 23% · C 41% · D 14%

Each period contributes 2k, and [2, 6] is two periods, so 4k.

Numerical integration: trapezium & rectangle rules

Rectangles and trapeziums

Split $[a, b]$ into n strips of width $h = \frac{b-a}{n}$, with $x_0 = a, x_1, \ldots, x_n = b$.

The three estimates

$$L = h\left[f(x_0) + f(x_1) + \cdots + f(x_{n-1})\right] \qquad R = h\left[f(x_1) + \cdots + f(x_n)\right]$$

$$T = \frac{h}{2}\left[f(x_0) + 2f(x_1) + \cdots + 2f(x_{n-1}) + f(x_n)\right] = \frac{L+R}{2}$$

The trapezium rule is on the formula sheet. L and R aren't, but they're easy: left uses every height except the last, right every height except the first.

Study design check

The 2023–2027 study design names only the **trapezium rule**. Left and right rectangles are background (the "limiting value of a sum" idea, and older exams), and they make the over/under reasoning easier to see. The 2023–2025 VCAA questions in this guide's practice exams all use trapeziums.

Worked example 1 **All three estimates for x² on [0, 2]** 3 marks

Estimate $\int_0^2 x^2\,dx$ with four strips using (a) left rectangles, (b) right rectangles, (c) the trapezium rule. Compare with the exact value.

Theory

Split the interval into n strips of width h. Left rectangles use the left-hand heights, right rectangles the right-hand heights, and trapeziums average the two. Whether each over- or under-estimates depends on whether the function is increasing and on its concavity.

1 $h = 0.5$. Heights at $x = 0, 0.5, 1, 1.5, 2$: $0, 0.25, 1, 2.25, 4$.

Using $h = \dfrac{b-a}{n}$

2 (a) $L = 0.5(0 + 0.25 + 1 + 2.25) = 1.75$. (b) $R = 0.5(0.25 + 1 + 2.25 + 4) = 3.75$.

Using $L = h\left[f(x_0) + \cdots + f(x_{n-1})\right]$, $R = h\left[f(x_1) + \cdots + f(x_n)\right]$

3 (c) $T = \frac{0.5}{2}\left(0 + 2(0.25 + 1 + 2.25) + 4\right) = 0.25 \times 11 = 2.75$.

Using $T = \dfrac{h}{2}[f(x_0) + 2f(x_1) + \cdots + 2f(x_{n-1}) + f(x_n)]$

$L = 1.75,\ R = 3.75,\ T = 2.75$; **exact** $\frac{8}{3} \approx 2.667$. x^2 is increasing, so L under- and R over-estimates. It's concave up, so the trapeziums sit above the curve and T is an overestimate.

Using $f'' > 0 \Rightarrow T$ overestimates

Over or under?

Function on the interval	Left rectangles	Right rectangles	Trapezium rule
Increasing	under	over	depends on concavity
Decreasing	over	under	depends on concavity
Concave up ($f'' > 0$)	–	–	over
Concave down ($f'' < 0$)	–	–	under

Key idea

Picture the tops: a trapezium's slanted top is a chord. Chords lie *above* a concave-up curve and *below* a concave-down one.

Worked example 2 **Trapezium rule for ln 3** 3 marks

Use the trapezium rule with two strips to estimate $\int_1^3 \frac{1}{x}\,dx$. Is it an over- or under-estimate?

Theory

The trapezium rule joins points on the curve with straight lines. If the curve is concave up, those chords sit above it, so the rule overestimates. If concave down, it underestimates.

1 $h = 1$; heights $f(1) = 1,\ f(2) = \frac{1}{2},\ f(3) = \frac{1}{3}$.

Using $h = \dfrac{b-a}{n}$

2 $T = \frac{1}{2}\left(1 + 2 \times \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3}\right) = \frac{1}{2} \times \frac{7}{3} = \frac{7}{6} \approx 1.167$.

Using $T = \dfrac{h}{2}[f(x_0) + 2f(x_1) + \cdots + f(x_n)]$

✓ $\frac{7}{6}$, an overestimate: $\frac{1}{x}$ is concave up for $x > 0$ ($f''(x) = \frac{2}{x^3} > 0$). The exact value is $\log_e 3 \approx 1.099$.

Using $f'' > 0 \Rightarrow$ overestimate

Worked example 3 **From a table of data** 2 marks

A car's speed (m/s) is recorded every 2 seconds: $t = 0, 2, 4, 6, 8$; $v = 0, 6, 10, 12, 13$. Estimate the distance travelled in 8 s using the trapezium rule.

Theory

Distance travelled is the area under a speed–time graph. With only a table of data, the trapezium rule is the way to estimate that area.

1 $h = 2$: $T = \frac{2}{2}\big(0 + 2(6 + 10 + 12) + 13\big) = 56 + 13$.

Using $T = \dfrac{h}{2}[f(x_0) + 2f(x_1) + \cdots + f(x_n)]$

✓ About 69 m. Distance is the area under a speed–time graph.

Using $\text{distance} = \int v\,dt$

Trick alert: numerical-integration traps

- **Count strips, not points.** Five x-values make four strips.
- **End heights appear once** in the trapezium rule; the middle ones are doubled.
- **Left rectangles don't use the last height**, and right rectangles don't use the first.
- **Over/under for a function that changes concavity** can't be decided by the table above. Compute both, or compare with the exact value.

Summary

- $T = \frac{h}{2}[\text{ends} + 2(\text{middles})]$; $T = \frac{L+R}{2}$.
- Monotonicity decides L and R; concavity decides T.
- More strips give a better estimate.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2024 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 7

state average 42% of marks

© VCAA · full paper (p. 8) ↗

$f(x) = x\sin(x)$: trapezium approximation, the range of f' on an interval, a stationary point, sketching f'
Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 8) ↗

a. Trapezium rule, step $\frac{\pi}{3}$, on $[0, \pi]$ (3 marks · state average 1.5 / 3, 50%)

- Values: $f(0) = 0,\ f\left(\frac{\pi}{3}\right) = \frac{\sqrt{3}\pi}{6},\ f\left(\frac{2\pi}{3}\right) = \frac{\sqrt{3}\pi}{3},\ f(\pi) = 0$
- Correct trapezium formula applied
- $\frac{\sqrt{3}\pi^2}{6}$

Answer / notes: $\frac{\pi}{6}\left[0 + 2\left(\frac{\sqrt{3}\pi}{6} + \frac{\sqrt{3}\pi}{3}\right) + 0\right] = \frac{\sqrt{3}\pi^2}{6}$

b.i. Find $f'(x)$ (1 mark · state average 0.9 / 1, 90%)

- $\sin(x) + x\cos(x)$

Answer / notes: $f'(x) = \sin(x) + x\cos(x)$

b.ii. Range of f' over $\left[\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{2\pi}{3}\right]$ (1 mark · state average 0.2 / 1, 20%)

- $\left[\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} - \frac{\pi}{3},\ 1\right]$

Answer / notes: $f'\left(\frac{\pi}{2}\right) = 1$ and $f'\left(\frac{2\pi}{3}\right) = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} - \frac{\pi}{3}$ (decreasing between them).

b.iii. Hence verify a stationary point in that interval (1 mark · state average 0.1 / 1, 10%)

- f' is continuous and changes sign (1 > 0 and $\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} - \frac{\pi}{3} < 0$), so $f'(x) = 0$ somewhere in the interval

Answer / notes: The range contains 0 and f′ is continuous, so it must hit zero. Only 12% got this.

c. Sketch $y = f'(x)$ on $[-\pi, \pi]$ with endpoints (3 marks · state average 1.1 / 3, 37%)

- Endpoints $(-\pi, \pi)$ and $(\pi, -\pi)$
- Odd-function shape through the origin with the given min (−1.1, −1.4) and max (1.1, 1.4)
- x-intercepts where f has turning points (≈ ±2.03)

Answer / notes: An odd curve from $(-\pi, \pi)$ down through ≈ −2 to the minimum, up through O to the maximum, then down through ≈ 2 to $(\pi, -\pi)$.

Probability: conditional & independent events

The core rules

Addition, conditional and multiplication rules

$$P(A \cup B) = P(A) + P(B) - P(A \cap B) \qquad P(A') = 1 - P(A)$$

$$P(A \mid B) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(B)} \qquad P(A \cap B) = P(A \mid B)\,P(B)$$

Mutually exclusive

A and B can't both happen: $P(A \cap B) = 0$, so $P(A \cup B) = P(A) + P(B)$.

Independent

One happening doesn't change the other's probability: $P(A \mid B) = P(A)$, or equivalently $P(A \cap B) = P(A)P(B)$.

Mutually exclusive ≠ independent

If A and B are mutually exclusive and both have non-zero probability, they're *dependent*: knowing A happened tells you B definitely didn't. $P(A \cap B) = 0 \neq P(A)P(B)$.

Karnaugh maps (probability tables)

A 2 × 2 table with totals is the fastest tool when there are two events. Fill in what you know; every row and column must add up.

Worked example 1 **Karnaugh map and independence** 3 marks

$P(A) = 0.6$, $P(B) = 0.3$ and $P(A \cap B') = 0.45$. (a) Find $P(A \cap B)$. (b) Are A and B independent? (c) Find $P(B \mid A)$.

Theory

A Karnaugh map (two-way table) makes every probability visible: rows and columns add to their totals. Independence means the joint probability equals the product of the separate ones.

1

	B	B'	total
A	**0.15**	0.45	0.6
A'	0.15	0.25	0.4
total	0.3	0.7	1

Using $P(A) = P(A \cap B) + P(A \cap B')$

2 (b) $P(A)P(B) = 0.18 \neq 0.15 = P(A \cap B)$: not independent.

Using independent $\iff P(A \cap B) = P(A)P(B)$

(a) 0.15; (b) not independent; (c) $P(B \mid A) = \frac{0.15}{0.6} = 0.25$.

Using $P(B \mid A) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(A)}$

Worked example 2 **Finding an unknown from independence** 2 marks

A and B are independent, $P(A) = 0.4$ and $P(A \cup B) = 0.7$. Find $P(B)$.

Theory
The addition rule links the union to the intersection, and independence lets you replace the intersection with a product. That leaves one equation in one unknown.

1 $P(A \cup B) = P(A) + P(B) - P(A)P(B)$: $0.7 = 0.4 + p - 0.4p$.

Using
$P(A \cup B) = P(A) + P(B) - P(A \cap B)$
$P(A \cap B) = P(A)P(B)$

✓ $0.6p = 0.3$, so $P(B) = 0.5$.

Tree diagrams and the law of total probability

Law of total probability

$$P(B) = P(B \mid A)P(A) + P(B \mid A')P(A')$$

Multiply along branches; add the branches that give the outcome you want.

Worked example 3 **The false-positive problem (hard)** 4 marks

2% of a population has a disease. A test gives a positive result for 95% of people with the disease and for 10% of people without it. A randomly chosen person tests positive. Find the probability that they have the disease, correct to four decimal places.

Theory
This is a "reverse conditional": you know $P(+ \mid D)$ but want $P(D \mid +)$. Use the law of total probability to find $P(+)$ from both branches, then the conditional probability formula.

1 Tree: $P(D \cap +) = 0.02 \times 0.95 = 0.019$; $P(D' \cap +) = 0.98 \times 0.10 = 0.098$.

Using
$P(D \cap +) = P(D)P(+ \mid D)$

2 $P(+) = 0.019 + 0.098 = 0.117$.

Using
$P(+) = P(D \cap +) + P(D' \cap +)$

3 $P(D \mid +) = \dfrac{P(D \cap +)}{P(+)} = \dfrac{0.019}{0.117}$.

Using
$P(D \mid +) = \dfrac{P(D \cap +)}{P(+)}$

✓ ≈ 0.1624. Only about 16% of positives actually have the disease, because the disease is rare and the false positives swamp the true ones. This is the classic "reverse conditional" and the answer surprises most people.

Worked example 4 **Without replacement** 2 marks

A bag holds 5 red and 3 blue marbles. Two are drawn without replacement. Find the probability of getting one of each colour.

Theory

Without replacement, the second probability depends on the first draw, so the denominators drop by one. Multiply along each branch, then add the branches that give the outcome you want.

1 $P(RB) + P(BR) = \frac{5}{8} \times \frac{3}{7} + \frac{3}{8} \times \frac{5}{7}$.

Using

$P(A \cap B) = P(A)P(B \mid A)$

add the separate orders

$= \frac{30}{56} = \frac{15}{28}$. Don't forget both orders.

Trick alert: probability traps

- $P(A \mid B) \neq P(B \mid A)$ in general, as the disease example shows.
- **"Given" shrinks the sample space.** Divide by the probability of the condition.
- **Independence must be checked with numbers**, not intuition.
- **Without replacement:** the second-draw probabilities change.

Summary

- $P(A \mid B) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(B)}$; independent $\Leftrightarrow P(A \cap B) = P(A)P(B)$.
- Karnaugh maps for two events; trees for multi-stage experiments.
- Reverse conditionals: build the tree, find the total, then divide.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2024 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 11 40% correct

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Choosing 3 of 12 students: probability exactly two are from the front row of seven

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 5) ↗

Answer: B · A 12% · B 40% · C 10% · D 37%

$\frac{\binom{7}{2}\binom{5}{1}}{\binom{12}{3}} = \frac{105}{220} = \frac{21}{44}$

Discrete random variables

Distributions

A discrete random variable X takes separate values $x_1, x_2, \ldots$ with probabilities $p_1, p_2, \ldots$. Every probability satisfies $0 \le p_i \le 1$, and together they sum to 1.

Mean, variance, standard deviation

$$E(X) = \mu = \sum x\,p(x) \qquad \operatorname{Var}(X) = E\big[(X-\mu)^2\big] = E(X^2) - \mu^2 \qquad \operatorname{sd}(X) = \sqrt{\operatorname{Var}(X)}$$

$$E(aX+b) = aE(X) + b \qquad \operatorname{Var}(aX+b) = a^2 \operatorname{Var}(X)$$

Worked example 1 **Full workout on a distribution table** 4 marks

x	0	1	2	3
$P(X = x)$	0.1	0.3	0.4	0.2

Find $E(X)$, $\operatorname{Var}(X)$, $\operatorname{sd}(X)$, and the mean and standard deviation of $Y = 3X - 2$.

Theory

The mean is the probability-weighted average of the values. Variance measures spread and is easiest as $E(X^2) - [E(X)]^2$. A linear change $Y = aX + b$ scales and shifts the mean, but only the scale factor a affects the spread.

1 $E(X) = 0 + 0.3 + 0.8 + 0.6 = 1.7$.

Using
$E(X) = \Sigma x\,p(x)$

2 $E(X^2) = 0 + 0.3 + 1.6 + 1.8 = 3.7$, so $\operatorname{Var}(X) = 3.7 - 1.7^2 = 0.81$ and $\operatorname{sd}(X) = 0.9$.

Using
$\operatorname{Var}(X) = E(X^2) - [E(X)]^2$
$\operatorname{sd}(X) = \sqrt{\operatorname{Var}(X)}$

3 $E(Y) = 3(1.7) - 2 = 3.1$; $\operatorname{Var}(Y) = 9 \times 0.81 = 7.29$, so $\operatorname{sd}(Y) = 2.7$.

Using
$E(aX+b) = aE(X) + b$
$\operatorname{Var}(aX+b) = a^2 \operatorname{Var}(X)$

✓ $E(X) = 1.7,\ \operatorname{Var}(X) = 0.81,\ \operatorname{sd}(X) = 0.9$; $E(Y) = 3.1,\ \operatorname{sd}(Y) = 2.7$. The -2 shifts the mean but doesn't change the spread.

Worked example 2 **Unknown probabilities** 3 marks

$P(X = x) = kx$ for $x = 1, 2, 3, 4$. Find k, $E(X)$ and $P(X > E(X))$.

Theory
Every probability distribution sums to 1, which finds any unknown constant. Then compute the mean as usual.

1 $k(1 + 2 + 3 + 4) = 1 \Rightarrow k = 0.1$. Probabilities: 0.1, 0.2, 0.3, 0.4.

Using $\Sigma p(x) = 1$

2 $E(X) = 0.1 + 0.4 + 0.9 + 1.6 = 3$.

Using $E(X) = \Sigma x\, p(x)$

✓ $k = 0.1$, $E(X) = 3$, $P(X > 3) = P(X = 4) = 0.4$. "Greater than" is strict: don't include $X = 3$.

Worked example 3 **Drawing without replacement** 3 marks

Two balls are drawn without replacement from a bag with 3 red and 2 blue balls. X is the number of red balls drawn. Find the distribution of X and $E(X)$.

Theory
Build the distribution from a tree diagram. The probabilities of all values must add to 1, which gives a quick way to find the last one.

1 $P(X = 0) = \frac{2}{5} \cdot \frac{1}{4} = \frac{1}{10}$; $P(X = 2) = \frac{3}{5} \cdot \frac{2}{4} = \frac{3}{10}$.

Using $P(A \cap B) = P(A)P(B \mid A)$

2 $P(X = 1) = 1 - \frac{1}{10} - \frac{3}{10} = \frac{6}{10}$ (or $2 \times \frac{3}{5} \times \frac{2}{4}$).

Using $\Sigma p(x) = 1$

✓ $E(X) = 0.6 + 0.6 = 1.2$ (which is $2 \times \frac{3}{5}$, as intuition says).

Using $E(X) = \Sigma x\, p(x)$

Worked example 4 **Is the game fair?** 3 marks

It costs \$5 to play a game: roll a fair die; a 6 pays \$20, a 5 pays \$5, anything else pays nothing. Find the expected profit per game.

Theory
The expected value is the long-run average per game. Profit is winnings minus the cost, and subtracting a constant subtracts it from the mean. A game is fair when expected profit is 0.

1 Let W = amount won. $E(W) = 20 \cdot \frac{1}{6} + 5 \cdot \frac{1}{6} + 0 \cdot \frac{4}{6} = \frac{25}{6} \approx 4.17$.

Using $E(X) = \Sigma x\, p(x)$

2 Profit $= W - 5$, so $E(\text{profit}) = \frac{25}{6} - 5 = -\frac{5}{6}$.

Using $E(X - b) = E(X) - b$

✓ About −\$0.83 per game, so the game is unfair to the player. A fair game has expected profit 0.

Trick alert: random variable traps

- $\operatorname{Var}(aX+b) = a^2 \operatorname{Var}(X)$. A negative a still makes the variance bigger: $\operatorname{Var}(-2X) = 4\operatorname{Var}(X)$.
- $E(X^2) \neq [E(X)]^2$. Their difference *is* the variance.
- **sd scales by** $|a|$, variance by a^2.
- **The expected value needn't be a possible value** (1.7 children...).

Summary

- Probabilities sum to 1; $E(X) = \sum xp$; $\operatorname{Var} = E(X^2) - \mu^2$.
- $E(aX+b) = aE(X) + b$; $\operatorname{Var}(aX+b) = a^2 \operatorname{Var}(X)$.
- Fair game: expected profit 0.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 12 — 29% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 6) ↗

Maximum possible mean of a pmf with parameter k

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 6) ↗

Answer: E · A 11% · B 14% · C 26% · D 18% · E 29%

All probabilities must lie in [0, 1], so $0 \leq k \leq \sqrt{5} - 2$. The mean $-3k^2 - 7k + 2$ is largest at k = 0, giving 2.

The binomial distribution

When is it binomial?

$X \sim \mathrm{Bi}(n, p)$ counts the number of successes when:

1. there's a fixed number n of trials;
2. each trial has two outcomes (success/failure);
3. the probability of success p is the same every trial;
4. the trials are independent.

Binomial distribution

$$P(X = x) = \binom{n}{x} p^x (1-p)^{n-x}, \quad x = 0, 1, \ldots, n \qquad E(X) = np \qquad \mathrm{Var}(X) = np(1-p)$$

$\binom{n}{x} = \frac{n!}{x!(n-x)!}$ counts the arrangements of x successes among n trials. For example $\binom{5}{2} = 10$.

Worked example 1 **Exactly, at least, at most** 4 marks

30% of customers buy a coffee. Ten customers are chosen at random. Find the probability that (a) exactly 3 buy coffee, (b) at least 3 buy coffee, (c) given at least one buys coffee, at least 3 do.

Theory

A binomial counts successes in n independent trials, each with the same probability p. "At least" is easiest via the complement. For a conditional, the intersection is often just the smaller event.

1 (a) $\binom{10}{3}(0.3)^3(0.7)^7 = 120 \times 0.027 \times 0.0823543 \approx 0.2668.$

Using $P(X = x) = \binom{n}{x} p^x (1-p)^{n-x}$

2 (b) $P(X \geq 3) = 1 - P(X \leq 2) \approx 1 - 0.3828 = 0.6172$ (CAS: binomCdf).

Using $P(X \geq a) = 1 - P(X \leq a - 1)$

3 (c) $P(X \geq 3 \mid X \geq 1) = \dfrac{P(X \geq 3)}{P(X \geq 1)} = \dfrac{0.6172}{1 - 0.7^{10}} = \dfrac{0.6172}{0.9718}.$

Using $P(A \mid B) = \dfrac{P(A \cap B)}{P(B)}$

$P(X \geq 1) = 1 - (1-p)^n$

✓ **(a) 0.2668, (b) 0.6172, (c) 0.6352.** In (c), "at least 3" is already inside "at least 1", so the intersection is just $P(X \geq 3)$.

Worked example 2 **Find the smallest n (Exam 2 staple)** 3 marks

A machine produces faulty items with probability 0.1. How many items must be tested so that the probability of finding at least one faulty item exceeds 0.95?

Theory

"At least one" is the complement of "none", so $P(X \geq 1) = 1 - (1-p)^n$. Solve the inequality with logs, and remember to flip the sign when dividing by the log of a number less than 1.

1 $P(X \geq 1) = 1 - 0.9^n > 0.95 \Rightarrow 0.9^n < 0.05$.

Using
$P(X \geq 1) = 1 - (1-p)^n$

2 $n > \dfrac{\log_e 0.05}{\log_e 0.9} \approx 28.43$. (The inequality flips because $\log_e 0.9 < 0$.)

Using
$a^n < b \Rightarrow n > \dfrac{\log_e b}{\log_e a}\ (0 < a < 1)$

✓ $n = 29$. Always round *up* for "smallest n". Check: $1 - 0.9^{28} \approx 0.948$ (too small), $1 - 0.9^{29} \approx 0.953$ ✓.

Worked example 3 **Find n and p from the mean and variance** 2 marks

$X \sim \text{Bi}(n, p)$ with $E(X) = 6$ and $\text{Var}(X) = 4.2$. Find n and p.

Theory

The binomial mean and variance share the factor np. Dividing the variance by the mean cancels it and leaves $1 - p$ straight away.

1 Divide: $\dfrac{np(1-p)}{np} = \dfrac{4.2}{6} \Rightarrow 1 - p = 0.7$.

Using
$E(X) = np$
$\text{Var}(X) = np(1-p)$

✓ $p = 0.3$, $n = \frac{6}{0.3} = 20$.

Using
$n = \dfrac{E(X)}{p}$

Trick alert: binomial traps

- **"At least 1" =** $1 - P(X = 0)$. Never add up 1, 2, 3, ... by hand.
- **Discrete inequalities:** $P(X < 4) = P(X \leq 3)$, and $P(X > 4) = 1 - P(X \leq 4)$. Off-by-one errors are the most common binomial mistake.
- **Without replacement from a small population isn't binomial** (the probability changes each trial).
- **Conditional binomial:** the numerator is the intersection. $P(X = 2 \mid X \geq 1) = \frac{P(X=2)}{P(X \geq 1)}$ because $X = 2$ is inside $X \geq 1$.

Summary

- Fixed n, two outcomes, constant p, independent: $\text{Bi}(n, p)$.
- $E = np$, $\text{Var} = np(1-p)$.
- "At least one": $1 - (1-p)^n$. For the smallest n, use logs and round up.
- Check every inequality sign: $<$ vs $\leq$ matters for discrete variables.

Hardest real questions on this topic

Nothing on this topic made the hardest third of 2023–2025, so this is the hardest one there is.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section A · Question 8 ★

49% correct

© VCAA · full paper (p. 4) ↗

Probability of at least one green in 8 draws with replacement

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 4) ↗

Answer: C · A 12% · B 14% · C 49% · D 16% · E 9%

$1 - \Pr(\text{no green}) = 1 - \left(\frac{m}{n+m}\right)^8$.

Continuous random variables (pdfs)

Probability density functions

A continuous random variable takes any value in an interval. Its **probability density function** f satisfies:

Conditions for a pdf

$$f(x) \geq 0 \text{ for all } x \qquad \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x)\,dx = 1 \qquad P(a < X < b) = \int_a^b f(x)\,dx$$

$P(X = a) = 0$ for any single value, so $<$ and $\leq$ give the same probability. (For discrete variables they don't!)

Summary statistics

$$E(X) = \int x f(x)\,dx \qquad \mathrm{Var}(X) = \int x^2 f(x)\,dx - \mu^2 \qquad \int_{-\infty}^{m} f(x)\,dx = \frac{1}{2} \text{ (median } m)$$

The pth percentile q satisfies $\int_{-\infty}^{q} f(x)\,dx = \frac{p}{100}$. $E(aX+b) = aE(X)+b$ and $\mathrm{Var}(aX+b) = a^2\,\mathrm{Var}(X)$, exactly as for discrete variables.

Worked example 1 **Everything about f(x) = kx² on [0, 3]** 6 marks

$f(x) = kx^2$ for $0 \leq x \leq 3$, and 0 elsewhere. Find (a) k, (b) $P(X < 1)$, (c) $E(X)$, (d) the median, (e) $\mathrm{Var}(X)$.

Theory

For a continuous random variable, probability is area under the pdf. The total area must be 1. The mean uses $\int x f(x)\,dx$, the median splits the area in half, and variance uses $E(X^2) - [E(X)]^2$ as in the discrete case.

1. (a) $\int_0^3 kx^2\,dx = 9k = 1 \Rightarrow k = \frac{1}{9}$.

   Using $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x)\,dx = 1$

2. (b) $\int_0^1 \frac{x^2}{9} dx = \frac{1}{27}$.

   Using $P(a < X < b) = \int_a^b f(x)\,dx$

3. (c) $E(X) = \int_0^3 \frac{x^3}{9} dx = \frac{81}{36} = \frac{9}{4}$.

   Using $E(X) = \int x f(x)\,dx$

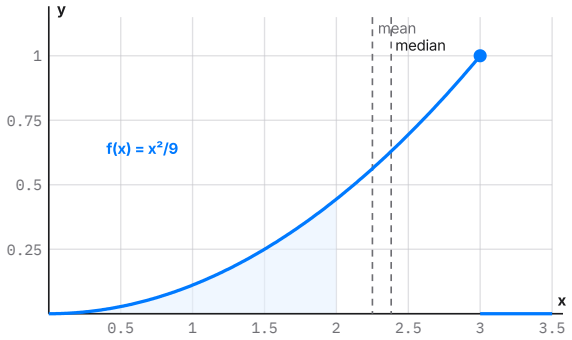
4. (d) $\int_0^m \frac{x^2}{9} dx = \frac{m^3}{27} = \frac{1}{2} \Rightarrow m = \frac{3}{\sqrt[3]{2}} \approx 2.381$.

   Using $\int_{-\infty}^{m} f(x)\,dx = \frac{1}{2}$

5. (e) $E(X^2) = \int_0^3 \frac{x^4}{9} dx = \frac{243}{45} = 5.4$; $\mathrm{Var} = 5.4 - \left(\frac{9}{4}\right)^2 = 0.3375$.

   Using $E(X^2) = \int x^2 f(x)\,dx$
   $\mathrm{Var}(X) = E(X^2) - [E(X)]^2$

✓ $k = \frac{1}{9}$; $P(X < 1) = \frac{1}{27}$; $E(X) = 2.25$; **median** ≈ 2.381; $\mathrm{Var} = 0.3375$. The median is bigger than the mean here because the distribution is skewed left (bunched at high values).



$f(x) = \frac{x^2}{9}$ on $[0, 3]$. The shaded area is $P(X < 2) = \frac{8}{27}$; the dashed lines mark the mean (2.25) and the median (≈ 2.38).

Worked example 2 **A piecewise (triangular) pdf** 4 marks

$f(x) = \begin{cases} x, & 0 \le x \le 1 \\ 2 - x, & 1 < x \le 2 \\ 0, & \text{elsewhere} \end{cases}$. Find $P(X < 0.5)$, $E(X)$ and $P(X > 1.5 \mid X > 1)$.

Theory

A piecewise pdf is integrated one piece at a time, each over its own interval. A pdf symmetric about $x = a$ has mean and median a.

1 $P(X < 0.5) = \int_0^{0.5} x\,dx = 0.125.$

Using $P(a < X < b) = \int_a^b f(x)\,dx$

2 The graph is symmetric about $x = 1$, so $E(X) = 1$ (and the median is 1).

Using $E(X) =$ line of symmetry

3 $P(X > 1.5) = \int_{1.5}^{2} (2 - x)\,dx = 0.125$ and $P(X > 1) = 0.5$.

Using $P(A \mid B) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(B)}$

0.125; 1; $\frac{0.125}{0.5} = 0.25$. For a piecewise pdf, integrate each piece over its own interval.

Worked example 3 **Exponential-type pdf (CAS)** 3 marks

The time T (minutes) between customer arrivals has pdf $f(t) = 0.5e^{-0.5t}$, $t \ge 0$. Find $P(T > 2)$ and the median time.

Theory

Probabilities for an unbounded pdf use an integral out to infinity, where $e^{-kt} \to 0$. The median is the m where the area to its left is exactly half.

1 $P(T > 2) = \int_2^{\infty} 0.5e^{-0.5t}dt = \left[-e^{-0.5t}\right]_2^{\infty} = e^{-1}.$

Using $P(T > a) = \int_a^{\infty} f(t)\,dt$; $e^{-kt} \to 0$ as $t \to \infty$

2 Median: $\int_0^m 0.5e^{-0.5t}dt = 1 - e^{-0.5m} = \frac{1}{2} \Rightarrow m = 2\log_e 2.$

Using $\int_0^m f(t)\,dt = \frac{1}{2}$

$P(T > 2) = e^{-1} \approx 0.368$; median $= 2\log_e 2 \approx 1.386$ min (less than the mean of 2 min: the long right tail pulls the mean up).

Trick alert: pdf traps

- $f(x)$ **isn't a probability.** A pdf value can be bigger than 1; only areas are probabilities.
- **The median is where the area is** $\frac{1}{2}$, not where f is $\frac{1}{2}$, and not halfway along the domain.
- **For a pdf, "find** k**" needs both conditions:** total area 1 *and* $f \geq 0$ (sometimes this rules out a solution).
- **Conditional:** $P(X > a \mid X > b) = \frac{P(X>a)}{P(X>b)}$ only when $a \geq b$ (so the first event is inside the second).

Summary

- pdf: $f \geq 0$, total area 1; probabilities are areas.
- Mean $\int xf$, variance $\int x^2 f - \mu^2$, median: area to the left $= \frac{1}{2}$.
- Piecewise: integrate piece by piece. Conditional: divide areas.

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2023 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 8

state average 32% of marks

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Queueing-time pdf $f(t) = kt(16 - t^2)$ on [0, 4]: find k, E(T), and a conditional probability

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 10) ↗

a. Show that $k = \frac{1}{64}$ (1 mark · state average 0.4 / 1, 40%)

- $k \int_0^4 (16t - t^3)\, dt = 64k = 1$

Answer / notes: $k \left[8t^2 - \frac{t^4}{4}\right]_0^4 = 64k = 1$

b. E(T) (2 marks · state average 0.8 / 2, 40%)

- $\frac{1}{64} \int_0^4 (16t^2 - t^4)\, dt$
- $= \frac{32}{15}$

Answer / notes: $\frac{1}{64}\left(\frac{1024}{3} - \frac{1024}{5}\right) = \frac{32}{15}$

c. $\Pr(T > 2 \mid T > 1)$ (3 marks · state average 0.7 / 3, 23%)

- $\Pr(T > 2) = \frac{9}{16}$
- $\Pr(T > 1) = \frac{225}{256}$
- Ratio $= \frac{16}{25}$

Answer / notes: $\frac{9/16}{225/256} = \frac{16}{25}$

2025 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 8

state average 44% of marks

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Continuous pdf: find k with Pr(X > k) = 9/16; integral of a transformed pdf

Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 10) ↗

a. Find k such that $\Pr(X > k) = \frac{9}{16}$ (3 marks · state average 1.4 / 3, 47%)

- Sets up $\int_k^{4/3} \frac{3}{8}(4 - 3x)\, dx = \frac{9}{16}$ (or the complement)
- Gets $9k^2 - 24k + 7 = 0$
- $k = \frac{1}{3}$ (rejects $\frac{7}{3}$, outside the domain)

Answer / notes: $k = \frac{1}{3}$. The other root $\frac{7}{3}$ is outside $\left[0, \frac{4}{3}\right]$.

b. $\int_0^{4/3} h(x)\,dx$ for $h(x) = mf(x) + n$ (2 marks · state average 0.8 / 2, 40%)

- Uses $\int_0^{4/3} f(x)\,dx = 1$
- $m + \frac{4n}{3}$

Answer / notes: $m \cdot 1 + n \cdot \frac{4}{3} = m + \frac{4n}{3}$

The normal distribution

The normal curve

$X \sim \mathrm{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$ has a symmetric bell-shaped pdf centred at μ (mean = median = mode), with spread set by the standard deviation σ. Note that the second parameter is the **variance**: $\mathrm{N}(170, 64)$ means $\sigma = 8$.

Standardising

$$Z = \frac{X - \mu}{\sigma} \sim \mathrm{N}(0, 1)$$

A z-score counts how many standard deviations a value is from the mean.

Interval	$\mu \pm \sigma$	$\mu \pm 2\sigma$	$\mu \pm 3\sigma$
Approx. probability	68%	95%	99.7%

Worked example 1 **Probability and percentile** 3 marks

Heights of adult men are $X \sim \mathrm{N}(170, 8^2)$ cm. Find (a) $P(X > 180)$, (b) the height exceeded by only 10% of men.

Theory

Standardising turns any normal variable into $Z \sim \mathrm{N}(0, 1)$. Going the other way, a percentile's z-value converts back with $x = \mu + z\sigma$. CAS inverse normal works with the area to the left.

1 (a) $z = \frac{180 - 170}{8} = 1.25$; $P(Z > 1.25) \approx 0.1056$.

Using

$$Z = \frac{X - \mu}{\sigma}$$

2 (b) Need $P(X > h) = 0.1$, i.e. $P(X < h) = 0.9$. Inverse normal: $z = 1.2816$, so $h = 170 + 1.2816 \times 8$.

Using

$P(X > h) = 0.1 \iff P(X < h) = 0.9$

$x = \mu + z\sigma$

(a) 0.1056, (b) $h \approx 180.25$ cm. CAS inverse normal uses the area to the *left* by default: convert "top 10%" into 0.9.

Worked example 2 **Using the 68–95–99.7 rule (tech-free)** 2 marks

$X \sim \mathrm{N}(50, 16)$. Without technology, estimate $P(42 < X < 54)$.

Theory

About 68%, 95% and 99.7% of a normal distribution lies within 1, 2 and 3 standard deviations of the mean. The curve is symmetric, so each half holds half of those amounts.

1 $\sigma = 4$. $42 = \mu - 2\sigma$, $54 = \mu + \sigma$. By symmetry, $P(42 < X < 50) \approx \frac{95\%}{2} = 47.5\%$ and $P(50 < X < 54) \approx \frac{68\%}{2} = 34\%$.

Using

68%, 95%, 99.7% within $1, 2, 3\ \sigma$

$\sigma = \sqrt{\mathrm{Var}(X)}$

≈ 0.815 (81.5%). Draw the bell and split at the mean.

Worked example 3 **Finding σ** 2 marks

The mass of a packet is normally distributed with mean 50 g, and 10% of packets weigh less than 40 g. Find the standard deviation.

Theory
A known percentile gives a z-value from inverse normal. Put it into the standardising formula and solve for the unknown parameter.

1 $P(X < 40) = 0.1 \Rightarrow \frac{40-50}{\sigma} = -1.2816.$

Using
$Z = \frac{X-\mu}{\sigma}$
$P(Z < -1.2816) = 0.1$

✓ $\sigma = \frac{10}{1.2816} \approx 7.80$ g.

Worked example 4 **Finding μ and σ together (hard)** 4 marks

For a normal variable, $P(X < 30) = 0.2$ and $P(X > 60) = 0.1$. Find μ and σ.

Theory
Two known percentiles give two standardising equations. Both unknowns appear linearly, so solve them simultaneously.

1 $\frac{30-\mu}{\sigma} = z_{0.2} = -0.8416$ and $\frac{60-\mu}{\sigma} = z_{0.9} = 1.2816.$

Using
$Z = \frac{X-\mu}{\sigma}$

2 So $30 = \mu - 0.8416\sigma$ and $60 = \mu + 1.2816\sigma$. Subtract: $30 = 2.1232\sigma$.

Using
$x = \mu + z\sigma$
subtract to eliminate μ

✓ $\sigma \approx 14.13$, $\mu \approx 30 + 0.8416 \times 14.13 \approx 41.89.$

Worked example 5 **Conditional normal, then binomial (Exam 2 chain)** 4 marks

Using $X \sim \mathrm{N}(170, 8^2)$: (a) find $P(X > 180 \mid X > 170)$; (b) ten men are chosen at random. Find the probability that at least two are taller than 180 cm.

Theory
A classic Exam 2 chain: a normal probability becomes the success probability p of a binomial. Carry the unrounded value through, or your final answer drifts.

1 (a) $\frac{P(X>180)}{P(X>170)} = \frac{0.1056}{0.5} \approx 0.2113.$

Using
$P(A \mid B) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(B)}$

2 (b) $Y \sim \mathrm{Bi}(10, 0.1056)$: $P(Y \geq 2) = 1 - P(Y = 0) - P(Y = 1)$.

Using
$P(Y = y) = \binom{n}{y} p^y (1-p)^{n-y}$
$P(Y \geq 2) = 1 - P(Y = 0) - P(Y = 1)$

✓ **(a) 0.2113; (b)** ≈ 0.2858. Use the unrounded probability from the normal part in the binomial part.

Trick alert: normal traps

- $\mathrm{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$: **the second number is the variance.** $\mathrm{N}(10, 9)$ has $\sigma = 3$.
- **Inverse normal = area to the left.** "Top 5%" means use 0.95.
- **Symmetry shortcuts:** $P(Z < -a) = P(Z > a)$, and $P(X > \mu) = 0.5$.
- **The 68–95–99.7 rule is approximate**, so use it only when told to (or tech-free).

Summary

- $Z = \frac{X-\mu}{\sigma}$; remember $\mathrm{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$ uses the variance.
- 68–95–99.7% for quick, tech-free estimates.
- Unknown μ or σ: turn each probability into a z-equation; two unknowns need two equations.
- Conditional: divide probabilities. Then feed an unrounded p into a binomial if needed.

Hardest real questions on this topic

Nothing on this topic made the hardest third of 2023–2025, so this is the hardest one there is.

2023 VCAA Exam 2 · Section B · Question 4 ★ — state average 49% of marks

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Tennis-ball diameters (normal), fitting through a container, grading, a confidence level, and serving-speed pdfs
Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 18) ↗

a. Pr(D > 6.8) (4 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.8 / 1, 80%)

- ≈ 0.1587

Answer / notes: ≈ 0.1587

b. Diameter exceeded by only 10% of balls (2 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.6 / 1, 60%)

- ≈ 6.83 cm

Answer / notes: 90th percentile ≈ 6.83 cm

c. Pr(ball fits: D < 6.95) (4 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.8 / 1, 80%)

- ≈ 0.9938

Answer / notes: ≈ 0.9938

d. Pr(at least 3 of 4 fit) (4 d.p.) (2 marks · state average 1.3 / 2, 65%)

- Binomial with n = 4, p = 0.9938
- ≈ 0.9998

Answer / notes: ≈ 0.9998

e. Pr(grade A | fits) (4 d.p.) (2 marks · state average 1.2 / 2, 60%)

- $\frac{\Pr(6.54 < D < 6.86)}{\Pr(D < 6.95)}$
- ≈ 0.8960

Answer / notes: ≈ 0.8960

f. σ so that more than 99% are grade A (2 d.p.) (2 marks · state average 0.7 / 2, 35%)

- $\frac{0.16}{\sigma} = 2.5758$
- $\sigma \approx 0.06$ cm

Answer / notes: Symmetric interval, so 0.5% in each tail.

g. Confidence level of the interval (0.7382, 0.9493) with n = 32 (2 marks · state average 0.5 / 2, 25%)

- $\hat{p} = 0.84375$, margin 0.10555, so $z \approx 1.645$
- 90%

Answer / notes: 90%. Many found z correctly but then said 95%.

h. Pr(grade A serving speed > 50) (4 d.p.) (1 mark · state average 0.6 / 1, 60%)

- ≈ 0.1345

Answer / notes: $\int_{50}^{3\pi^2+30} f(v)\,dv \approx 0.1345$

i. Exact mean serving speed of grade A balls (1 mark · state average 0.6 / 1, 60%)

- $3\pi^2 + 12$

Answer / notes: $E(V) = 3\pi^2 + 12$

j. a and b in $g(w) = af\left(\frac{w}{b}\right)$ if the mean is $2\pi^2 + 8$ (2 marks · state average 0.2 / 2, 10%)

- Area stays 1, so $ab = 1$; the mean scales by b: $b(3\pi^2 + 12) = 2\pi^2 + 8$
- $b = \frac{2}{3},\ a = \frac{3}{2}$

Answer / notes: $b = \frac{2}{3}$, $a = \frac{3}{2}$

Sampling & sample proportions

Populations, samples and bias

A **parameter** describes a population (e.g. the true proportion p of voters who support a policy). A **statistic** is calculated from a sample (e.g. the sample proportion $\hat{p}$). Different samples give different $\hat{p}$ values, so $\hat{p}$ is a random variable.

- **Simple random sample:** every group of n members is equally likely to be chosen.
- **Bias** is a systematic tendency to over- or under-estimate. Examples: surveying only people at a gym about exercise habits (selection bias); voluntary online polls (self-selection bias); leading questions.
- A bigger sample reduces random variability, but it *doesn't* fix bias.

The distribution of $\hat{p}$

Sample proportion

$$\hat{P} = \frac{X}{n},\ X \sim \mathrm{Bi}(n, p) \qquad E(\hat{P}) = p \qquad \mathrm{sd}(\hat{P}) = \sqrt{\frac{p(1-p)}{n}}$$

For large n (a common guide is $np \geq 10$ and $n(1-p) \geq 10$), $\hat{P}$ is approximately $\mathrm{N}\left(p, \frac{p(1-p)}{n}\right)$.

Key idea

Quadrupling the sample size **halves** the standard deviation of $\hat{P}$ (because of the $\sqrt{n}$). Diminishing returns: going from $n = 100$ to $n = 400$ helps as much as going from 400 to 1600.

Worked example 1 **Mean and sd of p̂** 2 marks

30% of a town's households own a dog. Random samples of 100 households are taken. Find the mean and standard deviation of $\hat{P}$.

Theory

The sample proportion $\hat{P}$ varies from sample to sample. Its mean is the population proportion p, and its spread shrinks as the sample size grows.

1 $E(\hat{P}) = p = 0.3.$

Using $E(\hat{P}) = p$

$\mathrm{sd}(\hat{P}) = \sqrt{\frac{0.3 \times 0.7}{100}} \approx 0.0458.$

Using $\mathrm{sd}(\hat{P}) = \sqrt{\frac{p(1-p)}{n}}$

Worked example 2 **Exact vs approximate (a favourite trap)** 4 marks

With $p = 0.3$ and $n = 100$, find $P(\hat{P} > 0.35)$ (a) exactly, using the binomial distribution, and (b) using the normal approximation.

Theory

$\hat{P} = \frac{X}{n}$ with X binomial, so exact probabilities come from the binomial count. For large n, $\hat{P}$ is approximately normal, which gives an approximate answer.

1 (a) $\hat{P} > 0.35 \iff X > 35 \iff X \geq 36$. With $X \sim \text{Bi}(100, 0.3)$: $P(X \geq 36) \approx 0.1161$.

Using

$$\hat{P} = \frac{X}{n},\ X \sim \text{Bi}(n, p)$$

2 (b) $\hat{P} \approx \text{N}(0.3, 0.0458^2)$: $P(\hat{P} > 0.35) = P(Z > 1.091) \approx 0.1376$.

Using

$$\text{sd}(\hat{P}) = \sqrt{\frac{p(1-p)}{n}}$$

$$Z = \frac{\hat{p} - p}{\text{sd}(\hat{P})}$$

(a) 0.1161 (exact); (b) 0.1376 (approximate). Read which one the question asks for. For the exact version, the strict "$>$" matters: $X \geq 36$, not $X \geq 35$.

Worked example 3 **Exact distribution of p̂ for a small sample (tech-free)** 3 marks

A fair coin is tossed 4 times and $\hat{P}$ is the proportion of heads. Find $P(\hat{P} \geq 0.75)$.

Theory

For a small sample, the normal approximation is poor. Convert the proportion into a count $X = n\hat{P}$ and use the binomial distribution directly.

1 $\hat{P} \geq 0.75 \iff X \geq 3$ with $X \sim \text{Bi}(4, \frac{1}{2})$.

Using

$$\hat{P} = \frac{X}{n},\ X \sim \text{Bi}(n, p)$$

2 $P(X = 3) + P(X = 4) = \frac{4}{16} + \frac{1}{16}$.

Using

$$P(X = x) = \binom{n}{x} p^x (1-p)^{n-x}$$

$\frac{5}{16}$. Small samples: convert to a count and use the binomial.

Trick alert: sampling traps

- p **vs** $\hat{p}$: the formula for $\text{sd}(\hat{P})$ uses the population p when it's known.
- **Convert proportions to counts carefully:** $\hat{P} \leq 0.2$ with $n = 50$ is $X \leq 10$.
- **Bigger samples don't remove bias.** A huge biased sample is still biased.
- **sd of** $\hat{P}$ **depends on** $\sqrt{n}$, not n.

Summary

- $E(\hat{P}) = p$, $\text{sd}(\hat{P}) = \sqrt{\frac{p(1-p)}{n}}$.
- Large n: approximately normal. Exact: convert to counts and use $\text{Bi}(n, p)$.
- Random sampling controls bias; sample size controls variability.

Confidence intervals for proportions

The interval

Approximate confidence interval for p

$$\left(\hat{p} - z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}},\ \hat{p} + z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}\right)$$

$z = 1.96$ for 95% (≈ 2 tech-free), $z \approx 2.576$ for 99%, $z \approx 1.645$ for 90%. The **margin of error** is $M = z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}$, half the width.

What "95% confident" means

If we took many samples and built a 95% interval from each, about 95% of those intervals would contain the true p. The true p is fixed: any single interval either contains it or doesn't.

Worked example 1 **Building a 95% interval** 3 marks

In a random sample of 200 students, 60 walk to school. Find an approximate 95% confidence interval for the proportion of all students who walk, to 4 decimal places.

Theory

A confidence interval is the sample estimate plus or minus a margin of error. The margin is z times the standard error, where $z = 1.96$ for 95% confidence.

1 $\hat{p} = \frac{60}{200} = 0.3$. Standard error $= \sqrt{\frac{0.3\times0.7}{200}} \approx 0.03240$.

Using
$\hat{p} = \frac{x}{n}$
$\text{SE} = \sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}$

2 $M = 1.96 \times 0.03240 \approx 0.0635$.

Using
$M = z \times \text{SE}$
$z = 1.96$ (95%)

✓ $(0.2365,\ 0.3635)$.

Using
$(\hat{p} - M, \hat{p} + M)$

Worked example 2 **A 99% interval is wider** 2 marks

In a sample of 400 voters, 248 support a proposal. Find an approximate 99% confidence interval for p.

Theory
Higher confidence needs a bigger z, which widens the interval. The trade-off is precision: you are more confident, but the interval says less.

1 $\hat{p} = 0.62$; $\text{SE} = \sqrt{\frac{0.62 \times 0.38}{400}} \approx 0.02427$; $M = 2.5758 \times 0.02427 \approx 0.0625$.

Using
$\text{SE} = \sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}$
$M = z \times \text{SE}$
$z = 2.5758$ (99%)

✓ $(0.5575,\ 0.6825)$. The 95% interval is $(0.5724, 0.6676)$. More confidence needs a wider net.

Using
$(\hat{p} - M, \hat{p} + M)$

Worked example 3 **Working backwards from an interval (hard)** 3 marks

An approximate 95% confidence interval for p is $(0.52, 0.64)$. Find $\hat{p}$, the margin of error and the sample size.

Theory
An interval is symmetric about $\hat{p}$, so $\hat{p}$ is the midpoint and the margin is half the width. Put both into the margin formula and solve for n, rounding up.

1 $\hat{p}$ is the midpoint: $\frac{0.52+0.64}{2} = 0.58$. M is half the width: 0.06.

Using
$\hat{p} = \text{midpoint}$
$M = \frac{1}{2}(\text{width})$

2 $0.06 = 1.96\sqrt{\frac{0.58 \times 0.42}{n}} \Rightarrow n = \frac{1.96^2 \times 0.2436}{0.06^2} \approx 259.9$.

Using
$M = z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}$

✓ $\hat{p} = 0.58$, $M = 0.06$, $n = 260$.

Worked example 4 **Choosing a sample size** 2 marks

A pollster wants a 95% margin of error of at most 3 percentage points and has no idea of p. How many people should be surveyed?

Theory
With no estimate of p, use $\hat{p} = 0.5$: it makes $\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})$ as large as possible, so the sample is big enough whatever the true p. Always round the sample size up.

1 Use $\hat{p} = 0.5$ (which gives the largest possible margin): $1.96\sqrt{\frac{0.25}{n}} \leq 0.03 \Rightarrow n \geq \frac{1.96^2 \times 0.25}{0.03^2} \approx 1067.1$.

Using
$M = z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}$
$\hat{p} = 0.5$ (most conservative)

✓ $n = 1068$ (round up). This is why national polls often survey about 1000 people.

Using
n rounds up

Using an interval to judge a claim

If a claimed value of p lies **inside** the interval, the data are consistent with the claim. If it's **outside**, the claim is doubtful (at that confidence level). An interval never *proves* the claim.

> **Trick alert: confidence interval traps**
>
> - **Don't say "there's a 95% probability that p is in (0.24, 0.36)".** VCAA wants the "95% of such intervals" interpretation.
> - **Higher confidence → wider interval; larger n → narrower.** To halve the width, quadruple n.
> - **Round sample sizes up**, even from 1067.1.
> - **The interval is about the population**, not about future samples.

Summary

- $\hat{p} \pm z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n}}$ with $z = 1.96$ (95%).
- Midpoint = $\hat{p}$; half-width = margin of error.
- Sample size: rearrange for n, use $\hat{p} = 0.5$ if unknown, round up.
- Interpret as "95% of such intervals contain p".

Hardest real questions on this topic

From the hardest third of the 2023–2025 exams. Try each one before reading the answer.

2023 VCAA Exam 1 · Question 6 — state average 35% of marks

© VCAA · full paper (p. 7) ↗

Working backwards from an approximate 95% confidence interval (0.04, 0.16)
Open the question in the official exam PDF (p. 7) ↗

a. $\hat{p}$ used (1 mark · state average 0.5 / 1, 50%)

- 0.1

Answer / notes: The midpoint: $\hat{p} = 0.10$.

b. Sample size (z = 2) (2 marks · state average 0.7 / 2, 35%)

- Margin $0.06 = 2\sqrt{\frac{0.1 \times 0.9}{n}}$
- $n = 100$

Answer / notes: $\sqrt{\frac{0.09}{n}} = 0.03 \Rightarrow n = 100$

c. Effect on the CI width of a sample four times as big (1 mark · state average 0.2 / 1, 20%)

- Width is halved (factor $\frac{1}{2}$)

Answer / notes: Width $\propto \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}}$, so $\times \frac{1}{2}$.

About this reference

Notes are from the VCE study guide's Methods pages. Exam questions © Victorian Curriculum and Assessment Authority (VCAA), linked to vcaa.vic.edu.au. Answers, marking points and notes are paraphrased study notes built from the VCAA examiners' reports, not official marking schemes. State results are from the examiners' reports.